Bite The Hand That Feeds

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35752345.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Light Hope (She-Ra)

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Horde Lords AU, Canon Divergence, Canon Universe, Angst with a Happy Ending, Hurt/Comfort, season one, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)'s A+ Parenting

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Part 2 of Give Up The Throne - Princess of the Horde AU

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by n7punk

Summary

After following Shadow Weaver’s guidance and discovering the Sword of Protection, Adora is scrambling to take her place at the front of the Horde. The invasion of Thaymor is her first chance to prove herself or lose it all. The stakes are high, but there is more that she doesn't know about She-ra or *herself* that could change everything.
(Horde Lords Catradora AU)

Notes

Fic title once again from Alpha by Little Destroyer.

Thaymor

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora is kind of numb, but she is doing her best to focus on just one thing at a time. Catra is right that they need to focus on the invasion. It would be true even if they didn't have Shadow Weaver locked up in a cell downstairs. Thaymor has to go well or all the soldiers raiding it will suffer the consequences. Their victory and *safety* rests on Adora's shoulders now. Luckily, the plans are already in place, she just has to ensure that they go off without a hitch. She is tired from being up for most of the night, but she has to stay on top of things for everyone's sake.

She seeks out Scorpia again, because in the few short minutes that she has spent with her she seemed to be nicer than every other Force Captain that Adora has ever met. Octavia is certainly – in Catra's words – *a first class bitch* and she is the Force Captain that Adora knows the best. It's not really shocking that she would rather go to Scorpia for advice despite hardly knowing her. As she walks over to meet her, her Force Captain badge lights up with a three-sentence bulletin from Hordak.

"Shadow Weaver is currently incapacitated. Force Captain Adora is now acting Second. The Thaymor invasion is to take place without a delay," Hordak's grouchy voice comes through before the badge falls silent on Adora's lapel. No further elaboration is offered, and apparently no one is dumb enough to ask Hordak questions, because the badge stays silent as Adora and Catra wander until they find Scorpia in the Force Captain lounge. Technically anyone can walk in, but anyone who doesn't belong usually isn't dumb enough to try – usually. Catra and Adora used to play in here as kids when no one was around.

Now Catra accompanies her as she approaches Scorpia, but she assumes it is fine for Catra to be here if she is with her. Adora

certainly doesn't want to try to figure out how to lead an invasion on her *own*. Luckily, Scorpia salutes upon spotting her – which definitely feels weird, but kind of good when she manages to push aside the guilt wracking her over Shadow Weaver – and eagerly agrees to help her. Scorpia assures her that she has been on raids before and can walk Adora through the normal procedure, as well as bring her up to speed on the battle plan for this one since Adora was only added to the lineup *yesterday* and hasn't been briefed.

"Are you still coming with us? Shadow Weaver usually hung back and snapped at us for updates as soon as we finished," Scorpia asks as she shows Adora the plans in the debrief room. Adora goes to shoot Catra a look, but Catra is in the middle of scanning over the movement plans and doesn't catch Adora's eye. Adora doesn't really know the answer to that. She was supposed to lead some anonymous squad that she hasn't even met. With Shadow Weaver unconscious, it would be hard to find out who they are and pair up for the battle. Besides, she doesn't *have* to anymore.

"I am. I'll be near the rear with my squad. I can help coordinate if necessary that way. It will be more effective than just reporting back to someone who isn't even there," Adora decides. Whatever squad she was going to lead, she can put someone else in charge of that team should they show up to deploy. If Shadow Weaver hadn't informed them yet that they were going to be in the battle or who was leading them, all the better. Either way, she will be most effective with her own squad. Being near the back will help with their inexperience as well as Adora's ability to coordinate.

Her words make Catra's gaze finally snap up, their eyes meeting. There is a spark in Catra's eye, an intensity and excitement that immediately tells Adora she made the right call. She might have no idea what she is doing – when it comes to the sword still in her hand, or locking up Shadow Weaver, or leading a military operation, or even being out in the field – but she knows that if she does this right, not only will she and Catra get to be together pretty much whenever and however they want, they will both get a chance to contribute to the war effort.

She will make this work. She has to. The entire army is counting on her to pull this off, but most importantly, so is Catra.

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Adora has to learn the plan for the invasion in an afternoon so she can host a final debrief that evening. Everything feels like a blur after they leave Shadow Weaver's cell, but the knowledge that she is sitting down in the basement is always in the back of Catra's mind. At least the amount of information that they have to absorb keeps them both busy, not to mention running around preparing things and having to repeat their cover story as news spreads throughout the Horde that Shadow Weaver is MIA and Hordak has ordered a rookie to replace her.

It is probably for the best. It prevents either of them from freaking out about what they have done until they have the time to after the invasion. It is already hard enough to figure out the invasion itself. The plan is very straight forward, but the layout of the rebel base is baffling, with many small storehouses spread out in a large clearing. There is no defensive wall. Tactically, it is a terrible base, but if it was maybe built before the war and was just repurposed during it, then the layout makes more sense.

Catra and Adora stick together through most of the preparations, but when it comes time for Adora to debrief with the other Force Captains, she sends Catra a distressed look as they walk up to the door of the meeting room. Catra scoffs, projecting that she doesn't give a shit that she still isn't allowed inside, and tells Adora that she is going to go find their squad to let them know to gear up in case Cobalt hasn't passed along the message yet. Scorpia helped Adora make a list of people who usually get orders and arrange things – like everyone arriving to the transports on time – and they have spoken to everyone, but they have no way of knowing if everyone did their jobs.

Adora is new, after all. She doesn't have the fearsome reputation that Shadow Weaver did. Most people seem a bit shocked to be receiving orders from someone so inexperienced, even if word has spread and all anyone is talking about is either Shadow Weaver's mysterious collapse, Adora being her new replacement, or the invasion still being prepped tonight. The good news is that almost everyone already knows what they have to do, so everyone they checked in with told Adora that they were already on it.

Some of them seemed annoyed that Adora was micromanaging them when they already had their job handled. Adora is too nice. She always assured them that she was just making sure that everything was ready so the operation could be a success. Shadow Weaver would have had them cowering. No one had the balls to be outright rude to Hordak's hand-picked replacement – well, she is Shadow Weaver's really, but Hordak confirmed her position – but they wouldn't have dared to even be *flippant* with Shadow Weaver.

Catra knows that their squad should have been informed that they are on the roster for the invasion already, but she still goes to talk to them. She does it just to give herself something to do, but she considers it productive mostly because she knows that they must have a lot of questions and will have no problem demanding them of Adora as they deploy. Catra doesn't want them undermining Adora's authority right before the invasion. Despite the stressful circumstances, they have been handed a golden opportunity and Catra is determined that they will make the best of it.

Adora will be a good Force Captain. She will be such a good Second that Hordak won't even think about wanting Shadow Weaver back. The happier he is with Adora, the less likely he is to ask after Shadow Weaver's condition. He clearly doesn't give a shit if it isn't affecting operations, so it *won't*. Catra will do everything that she can to help Adora get this done. Their goal was always to work their way up to ruling the Horde. This isn't how they imagined doing it by a longshot, but it always seemed obvious that Shadow Weaver was grooming Adora to be her replacement growing up.

Finding the sword has proven that she was grooming her for more than that, but the She-ra problem will have to take a backseat. Catra swings by the armory to get Adora a sheath so she can keep the sword on her back without having to carry it, but after that she narrows her focus back on her task, finding their trio of squadmates in the equipment room. The second that she spots them, Kyle lights up with obvious relief and drops the piece of armor he was trying to adjust the buckles of. It clatters to the floor, causing Rogelio to sigh.

"Catra! Thank the stars. What is going on?" he asks as Lonnie turns around from her locker. Her attention was drawn by the clatter of the armor falling, but she seems to forget it the second that her eyes land on Catra. She narrows her eyes at her and points an almost accusatory finger her way.

"Seriously, what the hell? You two have been missing ever since last night and then we hear a rumor that Shadow Weaver is dead and Adora replaced her. Not a word from either of you, just Cobalt walking up and ordering us to prep for deploy in three hours," Lonnie asks, her tone disbelieving and a bit annoyed. Catra scowls, leaning up against an equipment rack and crossing her arms. At least Rogelio isn't asking questions, just cocking his head and looking at her, but he tends to be quiet when he knows that someone can't understand him anyway.

"Sorry that we've been too busy coordinating an *invasion* to check-in. Shadow Weaver is unconscious from using up all her magic this morning. She looks like shit, but she isn't dead," Catra corrects. The lie flows easily off her tongue after telling it to no less than four other people who asked what was going on with Shadow Weaver. Lonnie raises an eyebrow at her.

"Just like that? Isn't there someone more experienced that he could pull? Maybe somebody who *didn't* get their superior officer shot this morning?" Lonnie asks. She has that needling tone to her voice that she sometimes gets. It's the tone that she would get whenever Catra outperformed her so she wanted to dig at her for something else, like how she was never going to go anywhere

regardless of her skills because of her attitude. Catra feels her tail lash once with annoyance before she manages to get it under control and narrows her eyes at Lonnie.

"Shadow Weaver failed to maintain her shield and got *herself* shot on that mission. We recovered an invaluable magic artifact even having to haul her ass out of danger. Besides, Adora was already going to lead a squad for the invasion. You're lucky that she decided to tap you guys to bring along instead of going with the squad that Shadow Weaver initially assigned her. She said you weren't *ready*," Catra shoots back, resisting the urge to curl her lip enough to show off her fangs. The only reason she manages it is because she doesn't want her defensiveness to draw suspicion. She is always like this, but she also has something to hide right now.

"Oh, that's so nice of her!" Kyle pipes up at the same time that Lonnie scoffs.

"Like Shadow Weaver was going to let you go along either. We both know who she considered *ready*. If she were awake right now, you would be sitting back at the barracks, same as Kyle. I was already on a tank crew roster," Lonnie replies. Catra hisses before she can help herself, her fur bristling. Lonnie smirks, victorious. She knows she is right, and unfortunately, so does Catra, but that isn't how things are going to go *anymore*.

Shadow Weaver doesn't get to push Catra down and hold her head underwater now that Adora is in charge. Catra can use that to her advantage. Lonnie thinks this is temporary and hasn't changed her behavior to adjust for who is leading now, but after the invasion she will come to realize the same thing as the rest of the Horde: Adora and Catra run the show now. Catra manages to form her raised hackles into a smirk, pushing off the bookcase and crossing over to Lonnie so she can get right in her face.

"Careful what you say, cadet. Shadow Weaver isn't the one calling the shots anymore. Adora's in charge and I don't think she would take kindly to your threats. One word from me and she can pull

you off the lineup. Now suit up and make sure that Kyle doesn't trip over his own boots. I have to go help arrange the entire invasion while you sit around and wait for *our* orders," Catra tells her. Lonnie's expression twists, lighting a deep satisfaction in Catra as she turns and saunters from the room.

Catra has been an easy target for years. Shadow Weaver hating her made her an obvious choice for bullying by the other cadets. Even being on the same squad as her, Lonnie wasn't an exception to that, though she was one of the better ones out of those who targeted Catra. Being hated by the Second was hard, but being the Second's best friend – maybe even lover, if everything works out – comes with perks. After years of being powerless and constantly having to fight back, it feels good to walk away from an argument knowing that she is untouchable.

As long as this invasion goes well, anyway. As long as Adora stays Second. Catra will do everything she can to make sure that she does, though. Hordak is still a threat, but he has always been a distant figure of fear and he will stay that way as long as they feed him the right information. If anyone else were to be appointed Second, their deception about Shadow Weaver would be at a much greater risk of discovery. They need to stay in control to ensure that she stays in that cell.

They will. They have to.

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Adora has never felt like more of a failure and imposter than she does leading the debriefing, especially as she gives orders to people twice her age who actually know what they are doing – and what she is *supposed* to be doing – but it helps that she has at least one person in her corner. She is glad that she went to Scorpia for help. Scorpia keeps sending her encouraging smiles

and hopping in to cover things that Adora forgot or didn't know that she should address in the first place. If someone did that to Shadow Weaver, they would end up short on rations for a week, but Adora is grateful.

It is still a massive relief to dismiss the meeting and not have everyone staring at her, some disbelieving and some judgmental. The final one is mostly Octavia, though Grizzlor also seems to be annoyed to be taking orders from someone so young. Despite Adora's lack of experience in the field, she does have one thing none of them have, and that is experience with *Shadow Weaver*. She gets asked one or two questions that it is clear no one else knows the answers to despite how Adora can answer them in an instant.

She didn't realize it wasn't common knowledge where Shadow Weaver stashes the long-range comm hubs or why she has troops deploy in a radial motion. She thinks the meeting ends up proving why she was picked just as much as it displays her ineptitude. At least, she hopes. She shows that she is Shadow Weaver's protégé, but she supposes it is up to each Force Captain whether they think that is more important than experience. Whatever their opinion is, though, they can't do anything about it – Hordak gave the job to Adora. As long as this operation doesn't end in disaster, no one will dare to openly challenge her, even if they may gossip behind her back.

It's fine. It wouldn't be the first time. Adora knows there are a lot of rumors flying around about what happened to Shadow Weaver, some as uninformed as *she died* and some with enough details to know that she came back from a mission this morning injured and hasn't recovered since. Adora would be shocked if there isn't a rumor that she or Catra were the ones to injure Shadow Weaver so they could take her place, and those people wouldn't even be *wrong*, but the Horde rumor mill has always worked fast and dried up the instant a superior officer walked by.

Adora is now one of them. If she wants to know what is being said, she will have to ask one of her squad. She hears people

murmur and whisper as she walks by, but if they were discussing rumors, they shift to *what is she carrying* or *that's her, the new Second* whenever she is close enough to hear them. Catra could probably hear more, but Adora doesn't see her again until she is headed towards their transport at the end of the day, the invasion just moments away. Or at least, the beginning of it is. Catra is leaning against the outside of the transport, looking aloof as always, but she perks up upon spotting Adora.

"It's time," Catra greets her, grinning as her tail begins to sway behind her. She looks anxious – Adora is too – but also excited. Adora can't really summon up the excitement that she thought she would have about being in the field for the first time. There is so much pressure that all she can feel her is own anxiety. Part of her says to run back to Shadow Weaver's cell and let her out. She isn't equipped for this, but she doesn't have a choice. She has to live up to expectations. It is now or never.

"I think I need another week to get ready," Adora mutters under her breath, glancing around to make sure she isn't overheard. It's true, but she also wants to get this over with. Her anxiety isn't going to fade unless someone takes responsibility from her, and even that will probably make it worse because she will be out of control. Hopefully her nerves will make her sharp, alert enough to catch every detail, and everything will go fine. Catra rolls her eyes, pushing off the transport and raising her hand out to her. Adora blinks down at the leather band that Catra is holding.

"Scabbard for the sword. I know we're not likely to see much fighting, but you need your hands free even if it's just to handle comms," she explains. Adora lets out a soft breath, looking up to shoot Catra a grateful look as she reaches for it and pulls it on. It feels nice to hook the sword onto her back. It is secure and still easily available for her to grab, but she has two hands again. She has been afraid to let go of the sword all day. It was sitting awkwardly on the corner of the table for the Force Captains meeting, but it was still within reach then. She doesn't want to leave it behind for Thaymor, and she might need it out in the field. Carrying it handsfree is the best solution.

"We've got this. Come on, it's time to finally kick some rebel ass," Catra assures her, clapping her on the shoulder and jerking her head back towards the transport. Adora lets out a slow breath and nods, smiling for what feels like the first time all afternoon. She can always count on Catra to keep her grounded and motivated. Catra is right: it is time to finally get out in the field and do something good for the Horde.

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At first, the invasion goes well. At least that is the report over comms. Their squad is at the very back, waiting in the final transport with Adora as she manages things over comms. Scorpia and her squad rode along with them – as helpful as Scorpia was earlier, she was annoyingly talkative for the trip – but they deployed already, leaving the rest of them to sit around and watch Adora. She has a map up on a tablet in front of her, tracking everyone's progress on it as they surround the base.

Apparently the rebels are completely unguarded. They are ill-prepared for the attack when the first squads emerge from the tree line. A base so close to the edge of the Whispering Woods shouldn't let its guard down like this and they pay for it. Their own transport is close enough to see the domes of the small storehouses out the windows, but they wait with the door shut as Adora watches their progress. They have nearly swept the entire place before the troops meet their first resistance.

Every squad is calling in successful sweeps, the rebels fleeing deep into the woods and leaving their base exposed for the taking, before the call of *Princess!* goes up and everybody is on high alert. Catra makes eye contact with Adora for only a brief moment, a thread of anxiety passing between them, before Adora hunkers over her tablet.

She tries to coordinate her teams to attack the princess and hold the border of the base so the rebels don't re-emerge from the trees and try to retake it now that their backup has arrived. The squads around the princess aren't reporting in, though. They could just be too busy engaging in battle to report, used to their superior being back at the Fright Zone and not having to call in as the battle takes place, but Adora is alight with anxiety, her fingers drumming against the small shelf that she is using as a table.

"It's fine, they're experienced," Lonnie tells her, waving it off despite how she is watching intently out the small window in the front of the transport. She sounds convinced, but they all have to be alert. Adora looks up to make eye contact with Catra for a moment, her mouth pressed in a grim line, and Catra instantly knows that nothing is going to assure her short of every team calling in that they have captured and subdued the princess.

She pushes off the wall she was leaning against, uncrossing her arms and rolling out her shoulders. Adora looks a bit relieved already, so Catra throws her a smirk as she grabs a stun baton up from the rack on the wall behind her. She projects confidence as she casually clicks the button and the handle crackles to life, drawing everyone's attention to her.

"I was hoping to see action anyway," she tells Adora. Adora smiles, abandoning her tablet in an instant and making for the door of the transport.

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The base's layout is weird – the storehouses have a very unsecure design, built out of clay and brick with plenty of windows and doors – but Adora's priority is the princess. She leads her squad to where she first appeared. From there it is easy to follow the trail of destruction to where the fight is taking place. Even a single

princess can be a formidable enemy, but when they finally reach the scene of the skirmish, Adora realizes what the problem is.

It's the same princess that they ran into in the woods. Adora might not have seen much of that fight, but Catra told her about it. Catra thought that she was called Glimmer, and her teleporting powers make her difficult to *stop*. The destruction around her isn't actually from the princess – it is from the Horde's own weapons training on her and then firing right after she has teleported away. Everybody is too busy trying to hit her to comm in, apparently.

The scene they come upon is chaos, but the princess doesn't seem to be succeeding in doing much but exhausting their firepower and soldiers as they try to hit her and just destroy the Rebellion base further instead. That is until she happens to teleport nearby and she spots Adora and Catra, anyway. They are the closest ones to her, and the rest of Adora's squad launches forward to try their own luck at landing a hit, but Adora stands in place, as does Glimmer, as they meet each other's eyes and Glimmer's expression hardens.

Glimmer says something too quietly for Adora to hear over the chaos, but the shape of her mouth seems to be the word *you* twisted by malice. She vanishes in a shower of sparkles just as Catra is about to make contact. Adora has an expandable staff on her belt. It sits right at her lower back and is her usually preferred weapon, but instinct tells her to reach up to her shoulder instead, drawing the sword and holding it before her with two hands.

Whatever instinct or premonition she had, it's right. Glimmer materializes again several feet up in the air above her. It is likely meant to throw her off, but Adora raises her sword up above her head, ready to intercept the human cannonball. Glimmer only falls towards it for a few inches before she unleashes the blast of magic charging between her hands and teleports away, but the sword still saves Adora.

She doesn't know how she has this instinct, but she has an inherent trust in the sword that she will have to unpack *later*. In

her hands, it transforms into a shield without her consciously telling it to. The magic blast ricochets off it into the air and explodes above her head in a cascade of sparkles, light, and heat. The clearing created by the fight shimmers with magic, lit by the blast in an almost-whimsical wash of pink light.

Glimmer reappears on a nearby rooftop, glaring when she sees the shield still held above Adora's head and how ineffective her attack was. Adora feels the pull of the sword – well, now magically a shield – in her hands. She blows out a steadying breath, deciding that the instinct hasn't led her astray so far. As she hoists the shield up in the air, it transforms back into a sword in her hands. With tanks and soldiers surrounding them, Adora looks up in the air and speaks the words that she feels in her heart despite not knowing their meaning.

"For the honor of Grayskull!"

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It isn't just a flash of light this time. Catra turned in time to watch the magic blast ricochet and explode. She is looking directly at Adora as she transforms. Magic washes over her, her body expanding and that weird white outfit sparkling to life in time with a fucking tiara. Whoever She-ra is, she is definitely a princess. Adora glows golden when it is done, the power radiating off her seeming to halt every person in their tracks as they stare.

Every person but one. From the edge of the clearing, and arrow comes arcing towards Adora's chest, but it doesn't even get a chance to bounce off her armored chest. She moves with clean, surgical precision, swiping her sword through the air and cutting the arrow down its center. Before Catra can finish drawing in an awed breath, Adora launches forward in the air, leaping across the entire clearing in one movement and driving her sword into the

center of the building that the arrow came sailing out the window of.

It crumbles to dust beneath her, but not before she backflips away to the center of the clearing. Catra isn't even watching the archer as he tries to scramble from the rubble, only saved from serious injury by the fact that Adora's strike was strong enough for the largest chunks of debris left to only be the size of a fist. Catra only watches him out of the corner of her eye, her gaze still locked on Adora as she raises her sword and fires a blast from the gem in its hilt. Glimmer barely teleports away in time, but the blast hits the building behind her and causes it to explode, showering more dust and debris on the far end of the clearing.

Catra is transfixed along with the rest of the Horde soldiers and she at least – kind of – knows what this is. The rest of them are frozen, unsure who or what has appeared to fight on their behalf. Catra even sees a few soldiers aiming at Adora uncertainly, but no one fires. At the edge of the clearing, a soldier finally makes a move and tackles the archer as he stumbles away from the rubble, coughing and covered in dust. Adora watches it happen with that impassive expression she wore the last few times she was like this – then she raises her sword and once again aims the flat of it to shoot another blast of magic.

"Duck!" Catra calls a warning to the soldier, knowing exactly what is about to happen and that they aren't looking towards Adora. Their helmet turns and they quickly throw themselves away from the archer, who looks up just in time to see Adora unleash the blast. He manages to raise his bow, the brunt of the blast snapping it in his hands, but the force is still enough to send him sailing backwards. He lands with a harsh grunt and doesn't move. At that moment, the sparkly princess reappears.

"Bow!" she calls out, distressed, drawing all eyes onto her, but she quickly blinks out of existence and reappears at his side, trying to lift him up from the ground. Adora raises her sword again, but Glimmer looks up and sees it, glaring back at her. "This isn't over," she promises, her voice a dark threat that doesn't match with her

appearance, and then she vanishes in a burst of sparkles along with the archer.

The clearing goes silent. For several long moments, there is no sound or movement as everybody waits tensely for the princess's reappearance, but despite her words, she seems to know when she is beat. Nothing stirs except the gentle billowing of Adora's golden hair and dark cape. After several long seconds, a single soldier near the edge of the clearing cheers. The entire gathering joins in quickly.

Catra watches a flash of emotion cross Adora's face for the first time in this form, honest surprise in her eyes as she turns her head and blinks at the soldiers cheering her on from the edges of the clearing. A moment later, her hair falls limp and her glow flickers. A flash returns her to normal, the sword still clutched in her hand. Exclamations of surprise join the cheers as those who didn't spot Adora before she transformed realize what they just saw, but Catra doesn't care about anyone else in the clearing.

Her heart is pounding as she scrambles down the slight crater that Adora made when she landed in the center of the clearing – which is now more oblong in shape thanks to her attacks – and straightens up at Adora's side. Adora turns to her with an almost wonderous look in her eyes, hope dancing there like she almost doesn't believe what just happened. Catra grins and reaches out, tapping on the badge adorning her chest with a single claw.

"Congratulations on your first successful invasion, Second. Thaymor is the Horde's," Catra tells her. Adora lets out the breath she was holding and grins back.

Chapter End Notes

> If this chapter and the last fic didn't make it clear, a lot of people are lying or manipulating others, so there's a lot of misinformation that gets presented as fact. Everybody is an unreliable narrator whether they know it or not.

The Crystal Castle

Chapter Notes

> I have no idea what my uploading is going to be like for the next few weeks, but I do at least have the rest of this fic drafted so it's just down to editing and getting started on the next one. Sorry for any errors, but my brain is spinning inside my skull like a top right now. Vertigo's a bitch.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Once the princess is defeated, Thaymor crumbles before them. Adora is a little overwhelmed by all the people congratulating her during the process of reporting in afterwards, but they get to base secured. All the rebels fled before the princess even arrived. With her dispatched, they take the place easily. Force Captain Grizzlor is left in charge of looting the place and setting up a small outpost in its remains, so Adora returns to the transports and oversees loading and deploying the troops headed back to the Fright Zone.

Watching the number of transports dwindle is a bit of relief. After she drops the transformation and it sinks in that they have won, she feels exhausted. She barely slept the night before and the last day of adrenaline is catching up with her. She knows that she wouldn't have let anyone else run such a big operation on as little sleep as she had, but she didn't have much of a choice. She had to do it. It had to be her, and it worked out in the end. The invasion was a success, and Adora hears the other soldiers whispering in awe as she makes her way around the transports.

Just a little bit longer. Catra helps her. When people approach to ask what happened back in the clearing, Catra grins and boasts about the Horde's own princess. By tomorrow morning, Adora doubts there will be a single soldier left in the Horde who doesn't know the name-

She-ra. It's a whisper in the back of her ears, causing her to stiffen and look up. Catra is at her side, immediately noticing the change in Adora and sending her a questioning look out of the corner of her eye, but she didn't say anything. Neither did their squad, standing at Adora's back. A single word is hard to identify, but Adora swears that was Light Hope's voice again. It was a call, but too stiff to make it all the way to pleading. She swallows, glancing back at the sword slung over her shoulder and noticing the gem in the hilt is pulsing with a dull glow.

She looks up, eyeing the transports. There are still a number left, but they are staying here. It should be time for her and her squad to finally deploy and return to the Fright Zone. Rest is within reach, but there is a pull at the back of her mind again. She looks up towards the tree line. The Whispering Woods loom large, swaying sinisterly in the breeze. They could be concealing any manner of things, but right now the sword is reacting to something inside of them. She can feel a call within in her not dissimilar to the one that raised her out of her bed last night. She has to follow it. She doesn't know how not to.

She swallows, glancing around and finding Scorpia hovering around the entrance to their transport back. Aside from Grizzlor and Adora herself, she is the most senior captain here. Adora doesn't know how she feels about leaving someone she barely knows in charge in her stead, but she can't just take off without electing a replacement, and Scorpia has seemed nice enough. It isn't like there is anything left to do except leave themselves. Adora tucks her tablet under her arm and walks over to the Force Captain. Scorpia lights up almost instantly upon her approach, smiling at both her and Catra.

"I'm going to take Catra and check for stragglers in the trees. I don't want to leave this place wide open for the rebels to retake while we're gone. Scorpia, you're in charge of watching the transports while I'm gone. We'll be as quick as we can while being thorough," Adora tells her, holding her tablet out to Scorpia. Scorpia immediately lights up and nods eagerly, taking the tablet from her.

"You got it! Sure you don't want to bring some muscle along too to back you up?" she asks, glancing to the side at Catra. Adora can't help but notice her eyes sweeping down Catra. Her gut instinct stirs, telling her Scorpia is being *disrespectful*, but she forces herself to stamp it down. Catra is strong, but she doesn't show her muscle, and anybody not versed in magicats could make the mistake. Adora shakes her head as Catra's tail twitches in irritation.

"We'll be fine. She-ra's the muscle, anyway. Lonnie, you're in charge of handling comms if anything happens. Rogelio, keep an eye on Kyle," Adora says, turning back to face her squad. They have been surprisingly quiet throughout this whole thing, but she suspects they were just waiting until they were relatively alone in the transport to demand answers from her. Everybody else coming up and genuinely needing things from Adora forced their curiosity onto the backburner.

They are trained better than to let stuff like that mess up operations. Adora watches Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio all exchange glances, but after a moment Lonnie nods without challenging her and Kyle pouts a bit, clearly disappointed with his lack of a job – or maybe with just the fact that minding him is considered one of its own. They may have grown up together, but Adora is their superior officer now and that means taking her orders.

"Yes, sir," Lonnie agrees. She doesn't salute, but that is the kind of thing that she can get away with due to their closeness. Adora certainly doesn't care. She nods to Lonnie and turns towards the tree line, throwing Catra an unnecessary hand signal to tell her to follow. Catra is already in motion. She, like Lonnie, doesn't question Adora. At least not until they have made their way to the trees and are out of earshot of the clearing.

"What's going on?" Catra asks, ducking close so Adora can hear her with her voice so low. Adora bites her lip, reaching up and unsheathing the sword. The gem is now glowing solidly in the hilt, dull but insistent.

“I don’t know, but there’s something else that I have to find. You coming?” she asks, looking up to meet Catra’s eyes. Catra doesn’t hesitate to scoff and knock their shoulders together.

“Of course. What kind of stupid question is that?” she replies.

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Catra really hopes that running off to chase a magical feeling doesn’t become a habit for Adora, but at least she brings Catra along with her this time. The glow from the sword’s runestone almost seems to be guiding them, growing stronger as they walk. When they have to turn to go around an obstacle like one of the massive trees, the glow grows fainter to warn them that they have turned the wrong way.

Catra can’t help but worry if this is some kind of trap – and even if it isn’t, what they are being led towards – but Adora has that same look in her eye that she had when she ran out last night. She isn’t going to be deterred. At least they have Adora’s badge so they can call back for help if they end up walking into an ambush again. It helps that they aren't weighed down by someone who hasn’t been in the field – or any kind of serious fight, real or simulated – in years.

“Everybody’s talking about us! A lot of people were *really* worried about trying something this big without Shadow Weaver, but you earned your title, Adora. Lots of talk about She-ra on the channels,” Lonnie pipes up from the badge on Adora’s chest without prompting. Catra watches a grin bloom on Adora’s face in response. The short version they told people afterwards was that Adora has the ability to use Princess magic against them by turning into She-ra, but Catra already knows that she is going to have to get to work once they get back.

Shadow Weaver was a master of propaganda and manipulating the story. If Adora wants to be as successful of a Second, she is going to need to do the same, but she doesn't have the capacity for it that Shadow Weaver did. Catra is skilled at spinning stories, though, and she can be Adora's propagandist. Still, Catra isn't sure how she feels about encouraging the She-ra thing. Adora is so *different* transformed. This last time it almost seemed like she got pulled out of it when she had emotions. The implications of that are terrifying.

Catra never bought into the bullshit Shadow Weaver said about Princesses being violent and dangerous – after all, Shadow Weaver was using the same magic from the Black Garnet and was in control – but seeing Adora's expression stony is unnerving. There is also how She-ra seems to disregard the safety of others. They brushed against the topic this morning, but Adora glossed over it before they could really talk about it, and then Lonnie showed up. As Adora pauses to point the sword out in front of her and turn in circles, scrutinizing the strength of its glow, Catra finally speaks up.

"You almost shot that guy when you were She-ra," Catra says, quietly. Adora pauses, turning to look over her shoulder at her. Her brow furrows for a moment as she tries to catch up with Catra's train of thought. Catra sighs. "The guy wrestling Bow. You almost took them both out at once," she elaborates. The confusion on Adora's face clears. She shakes her head as she starts forward again, forcing Catra to follow her deeper into the woods.

"I was going to wait for an opening where I would hit just the archer. It was a stun blast anyway," Adora assures, her voice casual. To her, it clearly isn't a big deal. She lifts a branch up for Catra and throws her a small smile. Catra takes the opening, ducking beneath the leaves, but she isn't convinced. She is used to Adora being expressive and warm like *this*. She-ra lacks those qualities despite the light that she radiates. She-ra is righteous. She isn't kind like Adora.

“You sure?” Catra asks, her voice low as they continue walking. Adora’s brows tilt up together as she sends Catra a soft look that almost seems touched. She slows her steps so they are walking shoulder-to-shoulder despite how it is impractical in the thick foliage of the forest. Reaching out with her left hand, she cautiously takes Catra’s hand in her own. She seems to perk up when Catra doesn’t pull away, twining their fingers together.

“Yeah, I’m sure. You don’t trust me?” she asks, her voice teasing. Catra scoffs, rolling her eyes overdramatically and looking away with the motion to hide the blush she is sure must be building in her cheeks. She can’t help her reaction when they walk hand-in-hand like this, their bodies close because they *have* to be in order to fit side-by-side on the narrow animal paths that they are following towards their unknown destination.

“Of course I do. I just don’t know if She-ra is *you*,” she returns. That is what it comes down to. She just wants assurance that Adora is herself in those moments. She looks and acts differently enough that it isn’t a *given*. Adora draws to a halt, turning and looking at her for a moment with a frown pinching at her forehead. Catra raises a brow back at her. Given how different Adora is in those moments, she thinks her concerns should be obvious.

Adora’s expression suddenly settles into one of determination. Without warning, she raises her arm up in the air. Catra realizes what she is about to do a moment before she speaks the words, “For the honor of Grayskull,” in calmest way that she has voiced them yet. Catra startles back, watching the transformation happen in pieces. It is still the same process, Adora’s body expanding in a wash of light and her clothes changing as her hair billows out, but this time small elements like her bracers and tiara come later.

She isn’t under a time constraint thanks to immediate danger now, so she can take longer – if that is something that she is capable of choosing to do. It is somewhat soothing to see Adora pound her fist into her palm and spark the gauntlets into life around her wrists. It’s *her*, dumb and showoffy and unnecessary,

but Adora does stuff like that all the time. They practically grew up trying to one-up each other.

When the light of the transformation fades, leaving just the ambient golden glow that seems to come with She-ra, Adora grins down at her. It's open and honest emotion on She-ra's face. It is soothing even if it is annoyingly smug. Adora opens her mouth, no doubt to say something insufferable just to prove her point, but they both whip around when a bright light shines through the trees. From deeper in the Whispering Woods, a beam of light shoots straight up into the sky.

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The beacon is a signal for her. She just knows it. This is what they have been walking to find. Its appearance makes Catra uneasy, but Adora is certain it isn't a trap, so they head straight for it. Catra's tail lashes as she walks, her eyes darting around the trees as she scans for danger, but Adora is focusing on how it feels to be She-ra outside of a life-or-death situation. She still isn't sure transforming is as simple as saying the passphrase, but she had motivation this time regardless of if she needed it.

That first time, Adora didn't really know what was happening. She hasn't felt totally in control the other times either, operating on some magical instinct she doesn't usually have, but this time she isn't in battle and her mind isn't running calculations like it has to then. Her body feels different like this and the added height is certainly new, but mentally she feels in control.

Previously she had the same motivations, but it felt like She-ra might come to different conclusions based off them. Now she's just two feet taller. There is power coursing through her body, but she is getting a chance to actually take stock of the changes and process how they feel. Catra does seem to be at ease now that

Adora has transformed and is just being herself rather than a warrior, but Adora isn't done trying to assure her.

"You're my best friend," Adora tells her, because that definitely isn't something She-ra would say if she were just using Adora's body. It feels more like the other way around, actually. The sword lets her use She-ra's power and instincts, but no one else is acting through Adora with it. Catra gives a small, squeaky scoff, her fur fluffing up as she reaches over and shoves at Adora. In her current form, it does nothing. Catra's tail lashes as she sends her a dramatic scowl.

"You've made your point," she returns, ducking beneath a low branch and skittering ahead. Unless she needs to bound over buildings, being She-ra doesn't help Adora's maneuverability. She ends up vaulting over the branch, which gives a suspicious crack beneath her weight despite how thick it is, but it doesn't break underneath her. She takes a few long strides to make up the lost distance and reach Catra again.

"I wasn't going to shoot you when we found the sword either. I knew you would duck," she adds. She thinks that might be what this is all stemming back to. She knows that if they were paired up in a training sim, Catra wouldn't be bothered by Adora aiming at her – she has done it many times – and would just leap out of the way so Adora can hit her real target. Adora did essentially the same thing with the sword when she first transformed into She-ra, but she was running off a weird combination of her inherent instincts and magic ones.

It didn't occur to her that Catra had no idea what was going on and just saw her best friend get overtaken by magic. Until Adora scooped her up and got her out of there, she had no reason to think Adora was in control or on her side. Adora would have thought those doubts had cleared by now, but clearly not. Catra's tail is still lashing, but her fur lies flat as she shoots Adora a look that is clearly trying to be exasperated. There is just a little too much true relief there for Adora to believe it.

"Alright, I get it," she responds, but she still seems kind of nervous. Maybe just flustered. Adora pauses, considering her for a moment, and then decides to go for something only she would think to do. She bends down and scoops Catra up, causing her squeak and wriggle in her arms as she twists around trying to grab onto something solid. Adora lifts Catra so she is cradled on her back, her hands scrambling to clutch at Adora's shoulder.

Catra glowers up at her. Despite the glare, her cheeks are pink, her fur is fluffed up, and her tail is lashing back and forth where it is draped over Adora's arm. Okay, the last two *could* be signals of irritation, but in this case they definitely aren't. That is Catra's *flustered* face, the one that only makes Adora want to descend on her more. She kind of likes how small Catra is in her hands like this. She can pick her up normally, but it takes a lot of strength. As She-ra, Catra might as well be weightless, and she can cradle her easily thanks to the size advantage.

"Quit it!" Catra complains, but her tone is high pitched and utterly flustered as she pushes herself away from Adora's chest and manages to wriggle out of her grasp. She lands on all fours – probably because the fall wasn't long enough for her to get two feet under her – and takes off to get out of range of Adora's grabbing distance. That fluster means that Adora only wants to do it again, though.

Before Adora can take off after her, Catra yelps. The sound of scrambling and claws digging in follows. Adora's heart drops.

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Catra ordinarily wouldn't be unobservant enough to run straight off a drop like that, but ordinarily she isn't fleeing her *best friend* who thinks it is a good idea to pick her up in her muscled arms in the middle of unknown territory. Catra had to cut that off before

something bad happened, like an ambush or having to talk about her feelings. She wasn't expecting there to be a sheer drop just beyond the bushes, but it isn't that far, and she manages to dig in her claws to slow her descent.

As Adora hurries up to the ledge and calls down to ask if she is okay, Catra gets her first look at what was throwing up the beacon. It is a structure of some kind, angular and seemingly made with similar designs decorating it as those on the blade of Adora's sword, though the carvings are overgrown. A massive doorway marks its entryway. Catra stands up and dusts herself off, calling a vague assurance up to Adora as she eyes the ball of light radiating out from the temple's roof.

She watches the light vanish as Adora jumps down after her, landing with an impact that sends vibrations through the ground, but at least she doesn't leave a crater this time. She straightens up and stares at the weird temple along with Catra. Catra sniffs the air and swivels her ears, but she doesn't detect anyone else around them. It seems like they are alone, though who knows how long that will last. Even with the glowing light now gone, it was still an obvious signal that others could be heading in the direction of.

"Can you get us in? We need to get in or leave before someone else comes to investigate," Catra asks Adora, having to crane her head up to look at her. She kind of towers over her in this form and Catra doesn't at all feel petty about that. She certainly doesn't have any *other* feelings on it, especially not when Adora is capable of scooping her up and holding her so effortlessly. Adora tilts her head a little, inspecting the door from a distance, and then shrugs.

"One way to find out," she says, starting forward.

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There is writing etched on what seems to be the doorway, but as they approach, Adora notices an etching of the blade of the Sword of Protection on the ground. When they pause outside of it, the panel swings down to reveal it is a hidden ramp. Adora exchanges a cautious look with Catra, but whatever this is, it is inviting them in. It doesn't feel dangerous. Adora knows she probably shouldn't be trusting magical instincts that were suddenly implanted in her head less than twenty-four hours ago, but right now they are telling her to keep going.

Catra gives a small growl of displeasure as Adora starts forward down the ramp, but she follows her. She is on high alert again, her ears swiveling around as they start down an entrance hallway not dissimilar to the crystalline backdrop of Adora's dream. There is no sound except the echoing of their footsteps. There is little light, but it does emit from the etchings in the wall in low levels, almost like when just the emergency power is on in a section of the Fright Zone because some idiot blew something up.

At the end of the hallway, a massive cavern opens up. They both draw to a halt in its entrance. Catra eyes the place, scanning the room for danger out of the corner of her eye, but Adora fixes her gaze on the raised platform in the middle of the room, surrounded by columns. The sword is warm in her hands. Whatever this place is, she knows it's important. She feels her resolve harden. She needs *answers* and this is her first solid lead to finding them. She starts forward, ignoring Catra's reluctant sigh of *Adora…*

She knows that this place is suspicious, but she needs answers and this is her best shot at getting them with Shadow Weaver incapacitated. There is a clear platform in the center of the room. Despite her obvious caution, Catra follows at a few paces behind her, pausing right at the edge of the raised dais. Adora comes to a halt in its center, casting her gaze around the room. There are other doorways branching off from this room, but they are dark and the last thing she wants to do is get them lost in an underground labyrinth.

"Okay, so what now? This place is weird. I don't like it," Catra says from behind her, a disdain creeping into her tone that Adora knows means she is likely trying to cover up another reaction. She glances back to find Catra's eyes narrowed as she looks around the room. Adora bites her lip. There isn't a guide anywhere or instructions for what to do. Well, actually, there are designs on some of the columns. She squints at the etchings, realizing there is *something* to guide her.

"There's writing," she tells Catra, though she doesn't know how much it helps. It doesn't tell her what to do.

"Writing," Catra replies, flatly, her disbelief obvious. Adora shrugs, aware the alphabet looks weird, but the geometric shapes are still linked to sound in her heads. Behind her, Catra gives a slightly scoff. "You've finally lost it, Adora. What does the *wall* say?" she asks, her tone sarcastic. Adora huffs and sends her a look over her shoulder to make it clear that Catra's tough skeptic act doesn't work on her, especially not when her tail is twitching nervously behind her.

"It just says 'She-ra'-" she starts to say, cutting off when there is a quiet *whirr* noise, and then in an instant lights flicker to life around them. She and Catra both wince, raising their arms to cover their eyes and cut the brightness a bit as machinery begins to hum in the walls of the chamber itself. A moment later, unseen fans kick into high gear, creating an artificial wind that billows the dust up off the floor. Adora winces, coughing a little and closing her eyes against the sting, but beside her Catra begins to hack.

Adora follows the sound with her eyes closed, reaching out a bit blindly until her hand lands on Catra and she quickly pulls her close. She hunkers them both down to the ground, lifting her cape and using it wrap around their heads and creating a dust shield. For a few moments, Catra continues to cough right in her face, but Adora holds it steady, squinting her eyes open to check on Catra. Catra's coughs subside as the cape at least cuts down on the contaminates from the mini dust storm billowing around them. They are close enough that Adora can see how watery Catra's

eyes are when she starts blinking them open despite the darkness in the small tent made by her cape.

Oh. There's a faint blue glow, and she is pretty sure it's coming from her own eyes. That's interesting. It is definitely going on the list of things that she needs an explanation for. Catra, now past her coughing fit, blushes as she realizes how close their faces are. Adora throws her a sheepish smile, but she tightens her arm a little around Catra's back, trying to discourage her from overreacting and pulling away.

It's a little awkward to cough right in your best friend's face and then share her air, sure, but it's better than getting suffocated in an indoor sandstorm. Catra quickly looks away with a *hmph*. It doesn't fool Adora, but she doesn't press it. They are very exposed in their current position and if Catra is busy being flustered then she won't be worrying about what is happening around them.

"Think it's trying to suffocate us?" Catra comments dryly. Adora chuckles a little, but she inclines her head to the side in the closest thing that she can manage to shaking her head right now. The wings of her tiara are tenting her cape above their heads and she is using her other hand to pull it down and hold either side of it closed between their chests.

"I think that's just the air turning on. Give it a minute. Clearly no one has been here for a long time," Adora assures her. That might be based on nothing and just what she is *hoping*, but she doesn't feel like the oxygen is getting any lower. It's hard to breathe, but there's still dust even inside the cape huddle and she and Catra are breathing in each other's exhalations. For several long moments, they just hunker there. Catra continues looking off to the side – it would be awkward as hell if they were just staring into each other's eyes this whole time – and Adora doesn't look away from her once.

It is rare that she gets an opportunity to be this close with Catra. The closest thing to this experience that she can think of is when

they have sleepovers and Catra actually sneaks up to the head of her bed. There seems to be less distance between them now than they usually left in the bunk though, and Adora swears it is getting smaller as she examines the shine in Catra's still-watering eyes and the light dusting of freckles on her cheeks from when she falls asleep up on high perches in full view of the sun, at least what little of it pierces through the smog of the Fright Zone.

Around them, the breeze slows as the fans die down. It takes several long seconds, but Adora counts it stopping as a blessing nonetheless. Her thoughts were starting to get dangerous. She was getting far too close to doing something stupid. It would have been especially risky given their location in a totally unknown ruin. Then again, they are already huddling with their heads covered, so they couldn't really make themselves easier pickings than they are now.

When the fans have died down to an inaudible level, Adora cautiously releases her cape and lets it slide to the side. The air is perfectly breathable again. It is less stagnant, though the breeze is gone. Some dust still clings to their clothes and Catra immediately turns away to have a small sneezing fit, but the cleaning protocol or whatever it was seems to have done its job. The surfaces around the room are gleaming in the light now. Adora places a hand on Catra's back and rubs it soothingly as Catra releases her tiny sneezes that still manage to reverberate in the empty hall. After a moment, the remaining dust settles and the sneezes subside, though her eyes are watering again when she turns back to Adora.

"I hate it here," she decides, blinking rapidly to clear her eyes. Adora's chest warms with affection, but before she can open her mouth to respond, they are both startled by a voice behind them.

"Hello. What is your query?" a tinny, robotic voice asks as a slight electric charge fills the air. Both of them yelp, clutching at each other instinctively and twisting around to come face-to-face with a hologram, now standing in the middle of the dais. It looks… odd, with elaborate robes and blue skin, but despite seeming more

lifeless and sounding less realistic than the woman that Adora saw when she touched the sword, she has a similar design.

She swallows, straightening up a little as Catra grumbles and releases her arm, taking a step back as if to prove to herself that she wasn't scared in the first place. Adora saw her tail. It poofed out like she had been zapped with static electricity. Teasing Catra isn't her top priority right now, though. Finally, someone – well, some*thing* – is offering to answer her. She steps forward, holding out the sword in front of her, though she isn't certain if the hologram can recognize it.

"I'm… She-ra, I guess. I came looking for answers about that and the sword," Adora tells her, not really sure how she is supposed to get answers out of her, but she needs them desperately. For half a second, nothing happens and Adora is afraid nothing *will*, but then the hologram's mouth stiffly begins to animate a moment ahead of the audio playing.

"Administrator *She-ra* recognized. Subject: Sword of Protection. Classification: Portable Runestone. Keyed exclusively to: Administrator She-ra," the hologram parrots. Adora blinks at her. That is pretty much what she knew before, although the phrase *portable runestone* is interesting. She knows all the Princesses have runestones that are the source of their powers, but she doesn't know what that means for her.

"What is She-ra?" she asks. There is another delay as the computer system seems to take several long seconds to process her request.

"Subject: She-ra. Classification: Princess of Power. She-ra is Etheria's champion, appointed to protect and unite the planet," the hologram tells her. That isn't much more than Shadow Weaver gave her, although having confirmation from someone who knows more than just legends is nice. The phrase *appointed* is interesting.

“Appointed by who? Light Hope?” she asks. The hologram flickers and for a moment she is afraid that she broke her, but after a moment she reappears.

“Multiple queries recognized. Records have been rewritten. Appointor now classified as: First Ones. Subject: Light Hope was created by the First Ones to train She-ra,” she tells her. Adora feels a strange sense of relief, her shoulders sagging a little. There is someone to *help* her. She has been looking to Shadow Weaver for answers all her life and suddenly losing that was causing her intense anxiety. It wasn’t likely that Shadow Weaver was going to give her answers from a prison cell, but if everything here is tech like it seems, there won’t be any emotional hang-ups to worry about. The holograms will just give her facts and teach her what she needs to know.

“Can we even trust this thing? Like, how does it know that?” Catra asks from behind her. Adora glances back over her shoulder to find Catra lurking a few feet back with her arms crossed, eyeing the hologram warily. Adora turns back to the hologram. If Light Hope was created to train She-ra, Adora can guess that this hologram was made as some kind of greeting program, but Catra does have a fair point. It’s hard to know who they’re actually talking to. The hologram would only know the facts that her programmers gave her, but they don’t know who those programmers were.

“Who were the First Ones?” Adora asks, looking up to eye the grand hall. With the lights on and dust cleared out, it is a marvel to look at. Color is everywhere, making the place seem more alive than the Fright Zone ever does despite how they are underground and alone. Whoever the First Ones were, they were clearly skilled architects. Their technology is impressive too, especially given its obvious age. When she looks back at the hologram, she is flickering again.

“Subject: The First Ones. Classification: Creators. The First Ones were explorers who ventured from beyond the stars to settle Etheria. For further information, see Light Hope,” the hologram

communicates through stuttering flashes. Adora winces. She doesn't know how much longer this thing is going to last, but she has barely gotten any of the answers that she needs. Shadow Weaver said there hasn't been a She-ra in hundreds of years, so this hologram is likely at least that old. She needs to find a better source of information, or at least one that doesn't seem like it could crash at any moment.

"Can I talk to Light Hope?" she asks. Light Hope seemed like she was a lot more solid and intelligent than this program. She is probably a safer bet for questions. The hologram did say that she was supposed to be the one to train She-ra. That probably includes teaching her what She-ra *is*. The hologram flickers for several long moments. Adora holds her breath, afraid that the next time she flickers she won't come back to life, but after a moment she solidifies again.

"You are not ready. You are on the wrong path," the hologram tells her. Catra scoffs behind her. Adora feels her own face screw up in response to that. She doesn't know what that means, but she doesn't think she is going to get a good answer out of this hologram. She just needs *answers*.

"How am I supposed to get on the right path if I can't talk to her?" she asks. The hologram says nothing, remaining motionless for a long moment before the flickering begins again. This time, the lights in the room join it, causing Adora to flinch from the rapid flashing. Behind her, Catra hisses quietly, likely shrinking back from the painful strobing as well, but Adora isn't opening her eyes to check.

For several long seconds, light flashes through her eyelids, and then there is a strange electric crackle and the lights come back on. Adora opens one eye cautiously, peeking out. Both her eyes quickly open wide as she looks up at the space where the hologram once stood, now replaced by the tall figure she saw in her vision. The woman looks down at her, expression impassive, before glancing to Catra. She frowns, her brows moving down in a single stiff sweep.

"The Crystal Castle was built for She-ra. Intruders should not be here," Light Hope says. Adora glances back at Catra, finding her dropping her arm back to her side from where she was shielding her eyes with it. Catra narrows her eyes at Light Hope, but being rejected by her is actually a good sign. Light Hope has a more recognition than the last AI they talked to, at least.

"If Shadow Weaver couldn't break us up, some program isn't going to do it," Catra snarks back. Adora can't help but smile a little as she turns back to Light Hope and nods. She already knows that Light Hope is more than just a program, but she doesn't blame Catra for thinking that given how simple the last hologram they talked to was. Light Hope's expression hasn't changed, clearly displeased.

"Listen, I found a magic sword *yesterday* and it turned my entire life upside down. I need answers. I don't really have a reason to trust you, so Catra stays. For all I know this entire 'castle' is a trap. You're going to need to give me something before I trust you," Adora tells Light Hope, gesturing to the sword in her hand as she speaks. Light Hope looks back to her, her eyes fixing on the sword. Her expression clears, returning to the blank neutral state it started in as she remains quiet for a few seconds.

"These are not ideal circumstances, but I must show you your destiny before you are led further astray. I have been waiting for you since you were an infant, but I could not reach you and I could not protect you from the Horde. Adora, you are She-ra. There have been many before you, but the line was broken. You are the first She-ra in a thousand years," Light Hope says, her voice tinging with regret and sadness as she speaks.

Adora almost feels like she has been slapped in the face. She recoils a bit, blinking up at Light Hope. Half of that information was old news, and the rest is disturbing. The whole *being watched* thing is creepy, but she doesn't know what Light Hope is talking about with her being led astray or needing protection *from* the Horde. Shadow Weaver was a harsh commander, but Adora is Second now. She's fine.

"What are you talking about? The Horde is my family. They've raised me ever since I was a baby," Adora returns. She is distantly aware of Catra edging closer to stand right behind her shoulder, following their old habit of forming up whenever someone tries to pick on one of them. Light Hope looks pained, shaking her head. Her movements are a bit unnatural, but the emotion on her face is lifelike despite her unusual features.

"The Horde *stole* you. They turned you into a soldier for their war. I could not stop them, so I watched, and waited for the day when I could unite you with the sword," Light Hope corrects. Adora flinches.

"That isn't right," she snaps back quickly. "Shadow Weaver taught me how to lace my boots and subvert the enemy. You don't know what you're talking about. You've been locked up underground for too long," she dismisses, but her heart is aching. The word *stole* implies there is somewhere else that she was supposed to be – a family that she might have had – but she knows that isn't right. Shadow Weaver told her that she was an orphan, like many of the other young cadets.

"Adora, the Horde is destroying Etheria in their quest for power. Everything on Etheria is connected. The princesses are granted powers over the elements with their runestones. When the princesses and their elements are in balance, Etheria functions as it should, but the Horde decimates everything in its path. Earlier today, they laid waste to a peaceful village and attacked a princess," Light Hope tells her.

Adora's heart freezes solid in her chest. That can't be right. Light Hope wasn't there, but Adora was. Sure, she was in the back of the transport until after all the rebels had fled, and none of them put up a fight like warriors should, and all the storehouses looked more like *homes* than parts of a military base, but there has to be an explanation for that. The rebels are less organized than she thought, or something. Everything she knows can't be a *lie*.

"As Etheria's facilitator, I am connected to the planet and can feel it falling further out of balance. You must rise against the Horde. It is your duty to bring the Princesses together. Only then can balance be restored to Etheria. It is what you were chosen for," Light Hope continues with no concern for the crisis happening inside Adora's head. That only makes things worse. The princesses are violent and unpredictable. Adora is meant to fight them, not unite them. None of this makes sense – not what Light Hope is saying, and now that she has told Adora more, not what she knows from the Horde either.

Adora feels She-ra flicker, her power wavering, and then a moment later she finds herself standing at her regular height, her gaze fixed down. The gem in the hilt of the sword is lifeless now. Light Hope didn't somehow cause her to revert, though – Adora did that, her doubt causing her form to waver. She stares down at the sword in her hand. Why does she trust this stranger more than her own knowledge? Holding the sword and being She-ra feels as right as it does confusing, but anyone could have fed this hologram information.

"Adora, we have no reason to trust this thing," Catra reminds quietly from behind her shoulder. Adora looks up in time to watch the lights flash red as Light Hope swivels her head to focus on Catra. Adora swallows at the look on her face. Catra is right that they have no reason to trust her, but the problem is that Adora *does*. Light Hope is connected to Etheria, just like She-ra is. Somewhere in the dark recesses of her mind that got activated when she touched the Sword, Adora knows that.

"You are an intruder. You should not be here. This information is for Adora only. She-ra should not be attached to others," Light Hope says. The lights flicker again, only this time they stay red. Adora doesn't need more than that and the danger in the air to take the cue to leave. She can't handle talking to Light Hope more right now anyway. None of this is right. Light Hope must work for the princesses somehow. She is trying to trick Adora.

Adora turns and grabs Catra's hand, yanking her with her as she charges towards the entrance that they came through. Catra barely gets out a "Hey!" before the door scrapes to life, starting to lower to trap them, but it is slow after all these years and they have a head start.

"Lockdown initiated," echoes out in the first hologram's voice right before an alarm starts ringing out, but Catra is sprinting along with Adora now and they manage to slide under the door before it can slam down. They run straight up the ramp, bursting out into the Whispering Woods before it can close too and trap them. The alarm cuts off as the ramp slides shut. They are instantly surrounded by the dark of night and the quiet chirp of insects. The only other thing stirring is the slight breeze that provides relieving fresh air Adora sucks in gladly.

Well, she supposes that she got some answers, but they weren't the ones she was looking for.

Chapter End Notes

> Not me rewatching and taking detailed notes to make sure that I got the lines right even though probably no one but me cares. Listen, Light Hope's speech seemed like it was very practiced. I bet she wrote that thing for years.
> I'm also certain that Light Hope has some kind of monitoring abilities using Etheria's network given that she says she watched Adora and she knows the Eternians are called First Ones now, so I think she would be able to detect two princesses fighting in Thaymor.

Etheria's Champion

Chapter Notes

> I said it on my tumblr, but I can't remember if I said it here yet, so I'll add that this is titled a "Horde Lords" AU because that's the commonly accepted term/AU, but it's really more of a "Princess of the Horde" AU.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

They escaped the weird castle – barely. Catra knew it had to be some kind of trap. They rest on the far side of the clearing from the strange castle entrance. The door never opens again. No sentinel comes bursting out to drag them back in. Once Catra catches her breath, she pushes off the rock she is leaning against and offers Adora her hand. Adora, plopped on the ground and still breathing deeply, looks up to her hand and then lets her eyes travel up to meet Catra's.

Catra can see distress in her gaze. She looks disturbed. Catra blows out a breath and pointedly twitches her fingers. After a moment, Adora reaches out and takes her hand, letting herself be pulled up to her feet. Catra doesn't know what to think of that creepy hologram lady. Stupid magical *bullshit*. She hates all this destiny crap. Light Hope just seemed like the AI equivalent of Shadow Weaver. On the other side of the war, clearly, but she was trying to fill Adora's head with the same bullshit.

"Let's get out of here. The others are going to start getting worried. We can't just vanish after a successful invasion," Catra tells Adora. She hopes it will bring her back down to Etheria, but instead Adora winces a little at the word *invasion*. As much as the hologram was talking bullshit, Catra can't deny that she was right about Thaymor. It just makes more sense for a place like that to be a town, especially considering that they were never met with resistance from the residents. That part isn't shocking to Catra though.

This is a war. That means taking civilian settlements as well as enemy bases, but of course Shadow Weaver would water it down for people like Adora who would hesitate if they were ordered to attack innocents. Not that Catra exactly wants to go around attacking random people, but she has never lied to herself about what they were inevitably going to have to do. They have to go through with it. It's their only chance to prove themselves. Even with Adora as the "temporary" Second, they need to keep their status, and Catra has to climb the ranks herself if they want to run the show themselves and finally be free.

Despite Adora's flinch, she nods, her expression heavy. Catra squeezes her hand, finally letting it go as she turns towards the edge of the clearing. They need to get back now. Whatever happened back in that castle needs to go into "deal with later" pile for now. They still need to report in to Hordak. Catra leads them around the base of the sharp hill that they dropped down, beginning to trudge back up it. She isn't sure which direction Thaymor is from here, but they don't have to walk in a straight line. She can follow their trail and retrace their footsteps back to where they first entered the trees.

Behind her, Adora is suspiciously quiet. After leading them straight to whatever that place was, she quietly lets Catra pull her along through the path of disturbed foliage. Catra feels her tail twitching with concern. Adora sounded *pained* when Light Hope started talking about the Horde. Part of Catra doesn't understand it: no matter the propaganda Shadow Weaver spouts, what they are doing should be obvious. On the other hand, Catra can name four different gaps in Adora's memory, not to mention whatever else Shadow Weaver got up to when she was alone with Adora. Those gaps are proof in themselves that Adora needed protection from the Horde, but Adora doesn't know about that.

"Do you think the princesses were using her to try to drive me away from the Horde?" Adora eventually asks. Her voice is small, almost hopeful, like she desperately wants Catra to explain away Light Hope's words. Catra hunches her shoulders. She doesn't know what to tell Adora. She didn't like that hologram or what she

had to say, but parts of it were definitely right. The rest of it was unverifiable, though none of it was necessarily surprising, so Catra is inclined to believe she was telling the truth, at least for the most part. The best way to manipulate someone is with elements of the truth, though.

Catra might not have liked the castle, but it could have been a way to get information without them having to rely on Shadow Weaver. She has a feeling Light Hope isn't going to let her back in now and Catra certainly isn't going to let Adora walk into a place that can turn into a giant trap just to get her head fucked with by someone new. Catra doesn't buy that Light Hope's motivations are completely altruistic. Nobody's are. She was programmed by somebody and Catra doubts that person truly just wanted all of Etheria to be balanced and peaceful.

"No, but she probably has her own reasons to use you. You know how I feel about destiny crap," Catra returns. Adora falls silent behind her. Catra keeps walking. They learned some useful stuff, especially about She-ra's supposed place in Etheria, and she is at least satisfied now that the sword isn't dangerous. Adora was apparently born She-ra, the sword just lets her access her powers. If Light Hope couldn't reach her before, when she had ample motivation to get her away from the Horde, then she shouldn't be able to do it now. Hopefully they can just use She-ra's powers without having to worry about all this.

"… Do you think Thaymor was a civilian town?" Adora asks, quietly, not content to just let it go. Catra sighs, drawing to a halt. She turns around to find Adora's head hung, her eyes flicking up to meet Catra's. Her expression is distraught. The pleading look in her eyes is begging Catra to say no. Catra doesn't know what the say – of *course* she thinks it was. She was suspicious from the moment that she saw its layout back in the war room.

"Just because she's right doesn't mean she isn't *creepy*. She's just another ancient Shadow Weaver," Catra returns. Adora recoils, looking away and wrapping her arms around her middle as if

trying to hug herself. Catra's tail lashes behind her as Adora's expression turns almost grief-stricken.

"She can't be. We're supposed to be helping – bringing *order*. Why should we trust her over our superior officers?" Adora asks, but she sounds unconvinced herself. Catra gapes at her as Adora tightens her arms around herself. "Everything can't have been a lie," she adds, her voice tiny. She sounds on the verge of breaking, desperately searching for answers. Catra feels anger spark in her heart along with a fierce protective instinct that doesn't fit with how annoyed she is with Adora right now. She wants to make things better and she also kind of wants to slap her.

"Maybe because Shadow Weaver tried to *attack* me yesterday and it wasn't even the first time? All Shadow Weaver does is lie, manipulate, and punish us! She doesn't seem like the kind of person who would help bring peace to a planet," Catra shoots back, unable to be delicate about it. The Horde doesn't even treat its own people well. How the hell would they do right by the citizens under their rule? Adora draws in a sharp breath, her eyes jerking up to lock with Catra's.

Seeing pain flash in her eyes at Catra's own words almost makes her flinch, but it is true. Adora is living in denial if she hasn't realized that by now, even with the memory games. The reminder of those is enough to take some of the wind out of her sails, though. Catra sighs, reaching up to smooth some of her hair back so it isn't curling over her mask anymore. She looks down, trying to find what to say. She doesn't want to go back to that place, but she knows that is all that Adora is going to want to do now that she has doubts.

"Adora. We could… fix it. Remember all our plans? Rising to the top of the Horde and ruling the world? If you really are Etheria's champion, whatever anyone else says that means, doesn't that also mean that you're fit to lead it?" Catra asks, stepping forward and reaching out to place a hand on Adora's shoulder. Adora bites her lip, her expression only easing slightly. It isn't enough to put

her worries to rest. Catra feels her tail lash behind her, her hand tightening on Adora's shoulder. She can't have her pull away, not now.

"You're already Hordak's Second. We don't have to have all the answers right now. We just work on securing your position. If the Horde is worse than the Rebellion, we could make it better now that we're in charge. And if not, we'll be helping the world by fighting the Rebellion. Taking charge from the inside will be the best way to end the war no matter who's right," Catra adds. This time, Adora's expression clears as some measure of relief creeps into it. The goalposts don't have to change for her: they can keep working on what they always wanted, they will just do different things with power once they get it.

"No one ever gives you credit for how clever you are," Adora tells her, her voice soft, as she reaches up and places a hand over Catra's on her shoulder. Catra manages to huff out a laugh, a bit relieved. She had a terrible feeling about what would happen if Adora went back to Light Hope for more answers. Catra doesn't trust her any more than she does Shadow Weaver, but at least she knows what Shadow Weaver wants and what she is willing to do to get it.

"Yeah, I know. For some reason they think you have the brains to come up with shit," Catra responds, her tone teasing. It feels good to have a moment of lightness after *everything* today, and Adora even smiles a little as she gently squeezes Catra's hand, but after several long moments regret creeps into her features again. She sighs, her gaze darting down and her shoulder hunching a little.

"I don't want to hurt people in the meantime, though. I hate causing pain," Adora says, guilt heavy in her voice. Catra's tail lashes behind her. Of course Adora would be worried about that. She has to be beyond reproach, doing everything perfectly, and temporarily causing pain while they wrestle for control isn't going to meet those standards for her, even if it would likely be the least bloody way to end this conflict.

“Adora, our plan will work. As long as you’re Second, you’ll be able to stop them from targeting civilians. We’ll rise in the Horde, and either we’ll rule the world, or we’ll save it from them. With your new status, we’ll be able to find out what the truth is,” Catra returns. She just wants to assure Adora, but she also has no reason to think that the Rebellion is good except maybe for the fact that they are standing up to the Horde. Adora lets out a slow breath, but she nods and makes eye contact with Catra gain.

“Promise?” Adora asks, softly, her gaze hopeful and small smile dancing on her lips. The assurance seems to have brought her some peace at least. Catra swallows, her heart beating quickly in her chest. She really does think this is the best way, but she is also happy to give any assurance that might stop Adora from letting her guilt complex drag her back into that deathtrap of a castle looking for answers.

“I promise. It’ll be fine as long as we’re together. We’ve made it this far,” Catra tells her, her voice low. Adora lets out a slow, relieved breath, and gives her a real smile now. It is still a bit tremulous, but Catra will take it. She means it. The rest of the world can wait. If it’s important to Adora, they will do their best to figure out what the “right” side is and make things better, but nothing really matters to Catra as long as they are together. Safety is Adora’s arms around her.

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Adora calls in over her badge to check how things are once they get close to Thaymor again and Lonnie confirms that none of the rebels have come back. It puts a bitter taste in Adora’s mouth. It feels like confirmation that they really were just civilians. Maybe Catra notices or maybe she is just competitive, but she nudges Adora’s shoulder and challenges to her a race back. Catra is going to win of course – she is faster, more agile, and has more senses

to pick up on their trail and thus has a better idea of where she is going – but it feels good to let go for a few moments can chase after her.

When they get back, Scorpia asks what took them so long. She doesn't sound accusing – Adora already kind of doubts she is capable of that – but genuine curiosity might be even more dangerous than suspicions. Before Adora can stumble to answer the question, Catra scoffs and walks on towards their transport, drawing eyes onto her and away from Adora's hesitance.

"Takes awhile to establish a perimeter in a new location and terrain. Adora had to show off her new powers to do dumb shit too. Slowed us down," Catra says. The excuse draws attention not onto what they were doing, but onto She-ra. It is a solid distraction. Adora was going to have to answer questions about her new powers eventually anyway, but she doesn't really want anyone except Catra to know about the Crystal Castle.

Their squad holds back while Adora checks in with Grizzlor one last time and they board the transport, but then an interrogation starts immediately. Scorpia might not be confident enough to challenge her herself, but she listens intently once Lonnie starts asking questions, her eyes darting between Catra and Adora. Once again, Catra comes to her rescue.

"What, did you think that Shadow Weaver went back into the field again for just any weapon? It's a *portable runestone*. Adora has the power of a princess at her fingertips. It changes everything," Catra scoffs when Lonnie asks what the hell happened back in the center of town. Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio all turn to look at Adora. For some reason, Scorpia only spares her a glance before looking back at Catra. Adora just shrugs, aware of the weight of the sword on her back.

"That's about all we learned before Shadow Weaver overexerted herself. She-ra is the Princess of Power or something. Shadow Weaver wanted me to use her to put an end to the war," Adora explains. Lonnie whistles, leaning back in her seat and crossing

her arms as she eyes the sword hilt poking out above Adora's shoulder.

"Don't suppose that thing works for anyone else? I could do without the hair, but that was some serious firepower back there," Lonnie asks. Adora immediately feels a spike of indignation in her chest and tries to stamp it down. It has been one day – a *confusing* day – and she can't believe that she is already feeling possessive of the sword, but being She-ra really felt amazing. Standing in the middle of that clearing with soldiers cheering her on felt *good*, at least before the doubt over what she had done set in. Even if she could share the power, she wouldn't want to.

"Bound just to me, apparently. Shadow Weaver said she was training me for it," Adora returns, shaking her head. Lonnie and Catra both wrinkle their lips in unison. Adora still isn't sure what Shadow Weaver meant by that – was her link to the sword somehow discoverable through magic? – but now that she is thinking about it, it lends more credence to what Light Hope said. If Shadow Weaver *stole* her, then it is possible there was some circumstance around her birth or her family that made it clear what she was.

Shit. She doesn't want to believe Light Hope. She has always believed so strongly in the Horde and her purpose here. Everything has changed since she found the sword. She needs *something* to hang onto. At this point, all she has is Catra. Catra is important, of course, but the idea of hurting people, destroying homes, and throwing an entire planet out of balance doesn't sit right with Adora. She just has to hope that Catra is right about changing things from the inside. The fact that she is even thinking like this might be proof enough that she thinks it is possible Light Hope is right, but she really hopes that she isn't.

"Can I hold it?" Kyle asks, raising his hand hopefully and looking at the sword with wide, curious eyes. He just sounds innocent and curious, like he wants to get a good look at it, but the way every person in the transport stiffens snaps Adora out of her thoughts.

"*No*," Catra, Lonnie, and likely even Rogelio says in unison. Adora doesn't need to speak lizardfolk to know that everybody – herself included – thinks that is a terrible idea. She isn't comfortable handing off the sword anyway, but she certainly isn't going to give it to someone who is likely to trip and fall on it. Kyle looks appropriately cowed even without Adora responding herself. Rogelio lifts a hand, placing it on Kyle's shoulder and guiding him to lean back into his side. He couldn't be projecting "I'm going to keep you close and make sure you don't kill yourself with klutziness" harder if he tried.

Despite her reluctance to hand Kyle pretty much anything important or dangerous, Adora is glad to have had the distraction. Her thoughts were starting to spiral back to a stressful place. They are almost back to the Fright Zone now and she is going to need to debrief with Hordak once they get there. She needs to be at her best for it. Well, the best she can be after having been up for nearly two days, usurping her superior officer, fighting a battle, and going through a crisis of conscience.

She really isn't looking forward to this.

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They split up when they get back. Catra doesn't technically have any duties now that the invasion is done, but Adora needs to go meet with Hordak and Catra doubts she is invited to that meeting. She walks away from the vehicle bay with Adora so their squad doesn't suspect that she is slipping off on her own and then they part ways so Catra can sneak down to the cells. Well, first to the cafeteria and then to the cells.

Adora can get Catra extra rations now, so for tonight Catra uses up the rest of her allowance for the week on ration bars. She purposely gets the brown kind. After all, they aren't for her. She

also nabs a solid steel cup for water, careful to stay out of sight as she heads down to the cell where they left Shadow Weaver this morning. She hasn't eaten since yesterday, but if she has woken in the last few hours, she at least had the small sink in the corner of the cell to get water from. It would have been undignified, but no one was looking.

Shadow Weaver is either still asleep or pretending to be when Catra arrives. She cautiously edges around her, not trusting her limp form. Shadow Weaver doesn't move as Catra sets the cup on the edge of the sink and makes a small stack of the ration bars against the wall. Afterwards, Catra hesitates near the entrance of the cell. Should she try to make her drink something? Should she poke her awake first? She doesn't buy that she is asleep for a second and she may try to lunge at Catra when she approaches.

After so long, Shadow Weaver needs to drink at the very least. Catra doesn't want her to waste away in here, she just wants her locked up where she isn't a danger. She is painfully aware of what Hordak said about Shadow Weaver dying without the Black Garnet though. Can she last in this prison cell? Is there even anything that they can do for her if not? She doesn't have the gem to access the Black Garnet's power even if they were willing to bring her to it and let her power up. She would be impossible to keep contained and quiet after that.

Right now, she is silent except for her breathing – a bit too fast for sleep, but it could just be strained – and her heartbeat. Catra stands near the entrance of the cell, unsure what to do. She wants to make sure that Shadow Weaver doesn't dehydrate or starve, but she doesn't want to open herself up to being attacked. Adora knows where she is, but she is going to be busy for a while now and unable to come down to check on them if Shadow Weaver does manage to get the jump on her. Catra decides to fold her arms and bluff.

"I know you're awake," she says, managing to force a tinge of annoyance into her voice. She can safely be as confident in this as she wishes; if she isn't right, then Shadow Weaver will be asleep

and unable to hear her mistake. For several long seconds, nothing happens. Catra narrows her eyes at Shadow Weaver's sleeping form.

"I'm not coming back down here for a while. This is your last chance," she says. She doesn't know if that will actually be true, but between the supply of ration bars and the water tap, Shadow Weaver shouldn't actually need anything for a while. Her arrow wound is pretty minor. Once the bandage comes off, it probably won't need further treatment. The ruse works, though. Shadow Weaver's stirs slightly, immediately turning her head and fixing Catra with a narrow-eyed look.

Now she is no longer feigning sleep, she doesn't look much more alive. Her mask is still in place, though cracked across the forehead, and she isn't moving. Her hair and robes are limp. She doesn't make any attempt to rise from the bed. Catra is too far for her to reach, the shackle keeping her from accessing the area immediately inside the doorway, but she doesn't even try to sit up on her own. Quietly, Catra wonders if she can. She doesn't talk either. Catra huffs, uncrossing her arms.

"The rations will last you a few days and there's a cup by the sink. Do you need help drinking?" Catra asks, projecting indifference. On the bed, Shadow Weaver gives a slight cough and finally makes to sit up slowly, seeming to wince a bit as she does so, though it's hard to tell with the mask. Once upright, she immediately turns to lean her back against the wall so she doesn't have to support herself.

"How *kind* of you," Shadow Weaver replies, her tone dry with a tinge of cruelty to it. Even locked up she is trying to be demeaning. Catra grits her teeth, resisting the urge to fist her hands at her side.

"Unlike you, I want my prisoners to be healthy. I could leave you in here with no food like you did to me. Now do you need help or not? I've got your job to do," Catra shoots back. Shadow Weaver could show an *ounce* of gratitude, but Catra knows that she

won't. Her pride is too strong. Shadow Weaver's eyes get impossibly thinner, but she raises her hand vaguely, holding it out and waiting. Catra scoffs, but she crosses over to the sink, keeping an eye on Shadow Weaver as she fills the cup.

She brings the cup to Shadow Weaver, noticing the way her hand trembles slightly as she takes the cup. She quickly backs away after handing it off. She doesn't trust that for a moment. It seems more likely that this is an act to get Catra to let her guard down. Shadow Weaver hates showing any amount of weakness. On the few occasions that Catra has seen her while her powers were running low and her strength was failing, Shadow Weaver was especially cruel in response to any show of sympathy or attempt to help.

"Do you truly think you have a chance at getting away with this? You have no idea all the I do. Hordak is going to realize I'm gone within a *day*," Shadow Weaver says to her after taking a long sip from the cup. Catra snorts, raising a brow at her. It feels good to know that she has the upper hand on Shadow Weaver for once. Shadow Weaver can try to sweettalk her way out of this cell, but she doesn't have anything to bargain with.

"Oh, as far as Hordak is concerned you went down on a mission to recover a weapon and couldn't be revived. Adora is Second now. She already proved herself leading the invasion of Thaymor. He didn't hesitate to replace you," Catra shoots back. She watches Shadow Weaver's eyeslits widen, her fingers tensing as she squeezes the cup in her hand. If it were glass – or she had the strength right now – Catra is sure it would shatter. She is quietly *furious*, but her hair and robe don't lash like they normally do when she is angered. She doesn't have the energy for it.

Catra feels victorious. It feels nice after all the stress she has been through today. She was really scared back in the Crystal Castle that Adora was going to throw away this opportunity over a moral crisis, and part of her is *still* worried about how doubtful Adora has been since some random hologram tried to tell her what to do. It feels good to finally achieve a victory over Shadow Weaver

after years of being at her mercy. Catra is telling the truth about Thaymor too. The invasion went well, even if the celebration of that got overshadowed by the anxiety of the magic bullshit that followed it.

"Where is she?" Shadow Weaver asks, still tightly clutching her cup. Catra scoffs, shaking her head. Yeah, like she is going to answer any questions Shadow Weaver asks. Giving her information is just giving her more ammunition to try to manipulate them with. That's what she does. She drank something at least and if she has enough energy to get furious like this, then she can walk to the sink or get herself a ration bar. Catra is fucking tired and she doesn't want to stay here long enough for that to show.

"Too busy to bother coming down here. One of us will be by with more rations before those run out. Get comfortable," Catra says, turning away and leaving before Shadow Weaver can call out after her. The door is blacked out so no one will spot Shadow Weaver inside, but Catra waits until she is out of sight of it entirely to heave a massive sigh. The night is almost over.

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Everybody Adora passes on her way to see Hordak congratulates her. It feels weird to be the center of so much attention. It seems that anyone who hadn't heard about her sudden promotion to Second has now, and word of She-ra is spreading fast too. People eye her sword and whisper excitedly when they see her if they don't try coming up to her and congratulating her directly. As Shadow Weaver's ward, most people seem to know of her at least in passing. Adora can't help but wonder if these people are trying to get in good with her early, but maybe the revelation of earlier just turned her cynical.

It isn't too late at night despite the sun having set – at least, it isn't if you slept the night before – and a decent amount of people are up to slow her progress through the halls, but she eventually has to turn away from the congratulations and questions about She-ra to make her way to Hordak. As good as the praise feels and as much as she kind of needs something like that right now, she has to do her job, and that means reporting in, even if Hordak should be more than aware of how the invasion went by now.

"I'm pleased with your work. You've done well, Force Captain," Hordak greets when Adora comes to kneel before his throne. Adora relaxes a bit at the praise, looking up and shooting him a grateful smile.

"We met some resistance from a princess, but I was able to dispatch her with the help of the sword. Force Captain Grizzlor is already making good progress on converting the town into an outpost," Adora informs him, rising up to stand, but keeping her head bowed a little respectfully. It isn't until after she has spoken that she realizes what she said, but Hordak doesn't hesitate over the word *town* at all. He doesn't seem to notice it, instead eyeing her sword hilt peeking over her shoulder. Either he missed it or it was old news to him and not worthy of comment. Adora feels a ball of lead sink in her stomach, the warm glow from all the congratulations instantly dispelled.

"Yes, it seems that it may have been worthy of sacrifice after all. Tell me, how does it work?" he asks. Despite his words, he doesn't sound all that interested. He sounds more like he is just relieved it wasn't a waste. Adora swallows, unsheathing it and holding it in front of herself for him to see. She does her best to focus on answering the question and not on the dark feeling settling in her stomach.

"From what Shadow Weaver told me, it seems to let me transform into She-ra, the Princess of Power," Adora explains. Hordak's expression doesn't change. Clearly Shadow Weaver kept whatever she knew about that to herself. Adora fidgets nervously with the pommel. She hoped he would be more impressed by that. She

lifts the sword up, as if to give him a better view of it, and then raises it above her head like she has the previous times that she transformed.

"I just say '*for the honor of Grayskull*'," she starts, pausing for the transformation, but nothing happens. Hordak's expression turns thoroughly unimpressed. Quickly, Adora hurries to lower the sword. "… and I transform into her. I'll, um have to train with her and learn what her abilities are. If you're okay with me dedicating some resources to researching her, I'll be able to utilize her more effectively," Adora tacks on. She probably should have thought about how She-ra needs more than those words to be summoned – Adora would bet determination is a key factor – but that definitely wasn't a good showing.

"Resource allocation was Shadow Weaver's job. As long as it doesn't decrease the troops' effectiveness, you may move things as you like. I expect a smooth transition. You have proved yourself in battle, but logistics is another task. I will not hesitate to replace you should you fail me," Hordak tells her, waving his hand dismissively. Adora swallows, quickly nodding and bowing. She already knew that given how easily he replaced Shadow Weaver, but it is still intimidating to hear him say it.

"I won't let you down," she assures him. When she looks up, she finds his expression unimpressed and uninterested. He doesn't care if she succeeds or fails. She wonders how much margin for error he will allow her before he goes looking for another replacement. If that happens, she and Catra are screwed. Their ruse will be immediately obvious. Adora swallows, her mind racing through disaster scenarios. Before she can spiral too far, Hordak abruptly stands, starting to walk around his throne and disappear behind it, but he pauses and glances back at her.

"Any update on Shadow Weaver's condition?" he asks. He sounds, at most, mildly curious, but questions like this are why Adora needs Catra with her. She isn't a good actress. Luckily, she doesn't have to lie when the question is as straight forward as this.

“I have been busy with the invasion, but the last I saw she was still unconscious. I had Catra check on her,” Adora replies. Hordak *hmphs*, turning away again.

“Dismissed,” he orders. Adora gives one last bow despite how he isn’t looking and then hurries to go. Finally, her serious duties are done for the day. She is almost too tired to tired to care about what is right or wrong anymore. She is eager to give in to the exhaustion bringing her to the edge of collapse as soon as she reunites with Catra.

Chapter End Notes

> Adora: Time to go straight to bed, sure glad nothing else is going to happen tonight!
> Chapter count: Sure it won’t.
> The comfortable lie is so much easier than the ugly truth.
> Adora will never be a conqueror, but staying on the path she always knew? That will feel right for far longer than it should.

Force Captain Quarters

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra finds Adora walking back to the bunkroom from Hordak's inner sanctum. She looks dead on her feet, but she smiles a little when she sees Catra. Adora clearly wants to ask her questions, sending her a wide-eyed look when she appears, but out in the open hallway isn't the place to talk about Shadow Weaver. If there was something urgent, Catra would pull her aside, but she thinks Shadow Weaver's current condition is the best that can be expected considering the circumstances. It is far lower on her priority list than sleep.

"Everything go okay with Hordak?" Catra asks, bumping her shoulder into Adora's as they fall into step together. Adora nods, lifting her hand to her mouth to stifle a yawn before she answers.

"He seemed happy enough with how Thaymor went. I think. I mean, he didn't seem *happy*, but said he was pleased with it. Told me not to fail him and stuff, but I'm still Second at least," Adora tells her. Her tone is a little dark and biting when she mentions failing. Catra bites her lip. They are under a lot of pressure. Failure isn't an option. Someone else becoming Second might as well be signing their tickets straight to Beast Island when they eventually discover what they did with Shadow Weaver.

They have to perform. Adora is clearly stressed and Catra is too. They really need some time alone to just relax, but the best they are going to get tonight is curling up in Adora's bunk together and going to sleep. Adora should get Force Captain quarters now, if not Shadow Weaver's old room, but Catra kind of doubts either of them has the energy to get them set up tonight.

"It'll be alright. We've got this," Catra assures, her voice quiet as they round the corner of hall to the bunkroom. They can't say

more without being overheard by those inside. Adora doesn't look very assured, though. Catra is just about to open her mouth again to make a joke, lighthearted and meaningless if it is overheard but hopefully still somewhat soothing, when she pulls up short upon stepping into the doorway to the bunkroom.

For some reason, Scorpia is inside with the rest of their squad. Rogelio spots them first, hissing something and causing everybody to scramble to stand at attention – and suspiciously, line up shoulder to shoulder to block view of Catra and Adora's bunk from the doorway. Catra is exhausted, but she isn't too tired to narrow her eyes at their squad, glancing between their caught expressions. Exchanging a glance with Adora, she finds her outright confused.

"Don't you have your own quarters? What are you doing here?" Adora asks Scorpia. She might be the most glaringly out of place part of the scene, but nothing is right with this picture. Scorpia looks side-to-side at what are clearly her co-conspirators. In turn, Lonnie exchanges a look with Kyle, who looks to Rogelio. Catra is too tired for this shit. She isn't above snapping at them for fucking with a superior officer on Adora's behalf. After a moment, everybody looks back to Scorpia despite the fact that all of them barely know her.

"When we were waiting for you guys to do your perimeter, we got to talking, and I realized that since you only got promoted yesterday, you're probably behind on stuff. I thought it would be a great surprise to get your quarters set up for you!" Scorpia explains, stepping aside to show off Adora's barren mattress. Catra blinks at it, a bit incredulous. Scorpia has been exceedingly nice and helpful all day, but Catra certainly wasn't expecting anything like *this* from someone they just met.

She wasn't even expecting it from their squad, but Kyle nods along with Scorpia's words eagerly, seeming to agree completely. Rogelio is more reserved, but he seems pleased. Lonnie looks mostly aloof, but she is watching their reactions, so she is at least somewhat invested. Adora looks downright touched. Catra

wonders if anyone touched either of their lockers. That's where most of their stuff is. If they did, did they move just Adora's stuff? Catra can see her ratty blanket up on her bunk still, but everybody knows she doesn't use it for anything other than kneading on.

"Aw, you guys, that's so sweet," Adora replies, placing a hand over her heart. Kyle and Scorpia both grin.

"Come on, I'll show you your room! I'm right next door," Scorpia tells her eagerly, starting forward to lead them out. Well, Catra supposes she will just have to find out how their squad decided to handle her unusual sleeping arrangements.

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The Force Captain quarters are bigger than Adora expected them to be. The bed is a huge four-poster. She has seen some of the other Force Captain quarters in passing when their doors were open. Their size and comforts vary, with the nicer ones mostly going to the more senior captains, but apparently being Second has perks. Her old blanket doesn't cover the new mattress, but it comes with its own set of bedding, the old blanket merely folded at its foot. Adora would bet one of her squad did that for Catra's benefit.

Everything from her own locker has been moved into the room, but Catra guards the combination to hers closely, so none of her things could be brought over. Catra wanders around the room as Scorpia eagerly walks Adora through every part of it, doing helpful things like pointing to the sink and saying, "And here's your personal Force Captain sink! No more walking to the locker room to brush your teeth!" Her squad lingers outside the doorway, watching Scorpia give the "grand tour." They could all fit in the room at once, but it would be a tight fit.

From how they hang back, Adora would bet this whole thing really was Scorpia's idea. She is unreasonably nice. Adora really is grateful to have a private room to share with Catra now – if they're going to get away with everything they are trying to do, they're going to need it – but she is absolutely exhausted and doesn't feel like she has the energy to be as grateful as she should be. She is relieved when Lonnie pushes off the doorframe and cuts in while Scorpia is taking a breath.

"Just thought it would be a nice way to congratulate you on the promotion and a successful mission. We'll let you enjoy it," Lonnie says. Adora could kiss her. She shoots her a grateful look as the rest of her squad makes to leave and Scorpia seems to realize how long she has gone on, nodding and heading towards the door.

"Right, of course! The walls are kinda thick, metal and all, so you'll have to come knock on my door if you need anything, but I'm happy to help!" Scorpia assures her, pausing within the doorway and turning back to beam at Adora. Adora offers her a smile that she hopes is grateful enough and not too tired. She can see that her squad is already making their way down the hallway, but Scorpia hesitates, glancing between Adora and Catra.

"I want to talk to Adora in private," Catra offers after a moment when it becomes clear that Scorpia is waiting for her to leave too. Scorpia looks oddly put out, but after a moment she rallies quickly and nods. She raises one pincer, waving as she takes a step back.

"Personal time! Got it! Well, I'll see you in the morning!" Scorpia responds in a rush, turning and finally walking away. Adora lets out a relieved sigh when the door closes behind her. For a moment, she just listens to the silence and appreciates having the only sound – other than the ambient noise of the Fright Zone that she is so accustomed to – being Catra's breathing behind her. She turns around to offer Catra a small smile.

"Well, that was sweet of them. We can go get your things from your locker tomorrow," Adora says. Catra's expression is oddly

stiff. She shrugs her shoulders, not looking at Adora. Adora feels a small ball of dread in her stomach. Shit, was that too presumptive? They've *always* slept together. Adora didn't think the promotion would change that. In fact, she has kind of been looking forward to getting to have a room alone with Catra. They would be able to sleep side-by-side instead of Catra being relegated to the foot of the bed and they wouldn't have to worry about getting caught being too close together.

Then again, Adora's thoughts about Catra have always been *close* in nature. Does Catra not want that? The best case scenario is that she doesn't want to keep sleeping together because of how obvious it will be when she is sleeping in an entirely different set of quarters, but the worst case is that Catra just doesn't want to do it anymore. Catra has seemed to want any time together that they could get, but maybe Adora was too presumptive. Maybe Catra has just *realized* how Adora feels about their closeness-

"Adora, stop that, I can hear you worrying," Catra cuts into her thoughts. Adora startles a little, looking up from where she had begun to stare a hole into her boots. Catra raises an eyebrow at her, taking a step closer as if inspecting Adora will allow her to read her mind. Adora draws in a sharp breath. They are *close* together now – and alone. Those two things are rare in combination, at least without something else hanging over them. They actually have a dozen things to be stressing about and trying to plan for, but Adora's mind has gone a bit blank.

"Do you not want to sleep here?" Adora finally asks, her voice soft. Catra stares at her, seemingly speechless.

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Catra is the master of *later*. *Later*, no matter how far or how close, is where all her hopes and carefully avoided consequences

lay. She isn't sure which camp this moment falls into, but it is definitely a *later* becoming *now*. She was never going to tell Adora about all the times they have kissed while Shadow Weaver was still around to wipe her mind again – then she would just be bringing it down on Adora's head – but there hasn't been a good time to pull her aside and tell her the truth over the course of the last day.

There was the invasion, and the fact that they could get caught at any time, and *She-ra*. They finally got a semi-quiet moment in the woods when they were walking back, but Adora was upset. Catra wasn't going to tell her something that would undoubtedly upset her more, but Adora's words are a reminder of everything that she still doesn't know. In Catra's mind, it seems impossible for anyone to doubt that all she has ever wanted is Adora, but maybe she is more subtle than she thinks, or the gaps in Adora's memory really are that wide.

Catra takes a step forward, bringing them practically chest-to-chest, and reaches up to caress Adora's cheek. Adora draws in a sharp breath, her eyes widening as she stares at Catra in clear shock. Carefully, Catra shifts to cup Adora's cheek like she did when Adora kissed her for the second time. She should have pulled away – she should have turned away every single time Adora tried to kiss her, truthfully – but she could never bring herself to do it. There was always the tiny hope that this time Shadow Weaver wouldn't catch them.

It was always false. This time, Catra offers Adora a small smile of assurance. Adora's breaths are a bit quick with anticipation, her heart racing audibly as she stares at Catra with a mix of confusion and hope. She really wasn't expecting Catra to do something like this. Shit, where is the girl who surged forward and kissed her while they were awkwardly straddled across the locker room benches and talking shit on the other cadets' times? Where is the confidence of the Adora who managed to wrestle her to the ground and then looked too long at her lips to be passed off as an accident in the midst of a playfight?

"Adora, this is the only place I want to be. I meant it when I said we could do anything as long as we were *together*," Catra tells her, trying to put all the weighty implication in her voice. She can't have Adora thinking that this – that *she* – isn't what she wants. Adora's breath hitches and her eyes tellingly flick *down*, lingering on Catra's lips for a long moment. Catra feels a slight smirk tug at them that makes Adora blush and quickly look up to make eye contact again as if that covers what she just did.

Adora's anxiety seems to have vanished quickly, but it was a ridiculous worry in the first place. Maybe it is just that it has been a few months and it is about that time again, because right now is definitely one of those moments that Adora doesn't remember. Adora's cheeks are warm with embarrassment, but she is also swaying forward into Catra's space almost hopefully. It is that moment of tension before a first kiss – for the fifth time. There have been better times, but there have also been worse ones.

For a moment, Catra thought Adora might kiss her back in the Crystal Castle, when their faces were forced close together as they sheltered from the dust, but this is better. They're alone, in what will become *their* room if they can get away with it, and they don't have to worry about anybody coming upon them without warning. They can take as long as they like, and they're going to need that time if Catra is going to finally follow up one of these kisses with an admission.

She is so *tired* of holding herself back from Adora. Her breath hitches when they gravitate together, close enough for Adora's breath to puff onto her face. Adora's expression is anxious and hopeful, but Catra can't move forward and initiate anything herself. With all that Adora doesn't know, it has to be her choice if they do this. Still, Catra inclines her body towards Adora and tilts her chin up a little, hoping Adora will take the invitation that she is offering her. Adora's eyes flick down again, but this time they linger on Catra's lips, and when their eyes meet again, Adora's have a spark to them.

"Catra, I-" Adora starts, her voice a whisper, and then cuts off like she can't get any other words out. Catra holds her breath, waiting for the rest. Instead, Adora just looks at her pleadingly, clearly needing *something* before she can move forward. Catra slides her hand down, hooking it around the back of her neck and lightly tugging Adora closer. Adora lets out a shaky, relieved breath, and then *finally* sways forward and kisses her.

The kiss is soft, cautious and afraid on Adora's end, but Catra has experience kissing Adora, so she meets her with heat. Adora makes a small sound beneath her lips, seeming surprised by how eagerly Catra is meeting her, but she raises her hands and lightly places them on her shoulders, holding her as she does her best to keep up with her. There's a desperation inside Catra fueled by four other kisses cut short or stolen from her shortly afterwards, but no one bursts down the door to pull them apart. No electric crackle hits the air and ruins everything that she has ever wanted.

Eventually, Catra has to pull back to breathe, but she doesn't step back or let go of Adora. In fact, she pulls more insistently on her, not wanting Adora to back away just because they need air. When Catra flutters her eyes open, she finds Adora looking at her with an awestruck expression, her eyes sparkling. Her shoulders rise and fall as she breathes heavily. Catra knows that was a bit *much* for a first kiss, but in her defense, one of those four kisses progressed all the way to making out. Catra knows a bit about what she is doing and she *needed* that.

As she stares into Adora's eyes, it hits her for the first time that there really is no one to pull them apart now despite how her body was tensing up and waiting for it. Catra's breath shakes with the revelation. Shadow Weaver is locked up. If Catra has anything to say about it, she will never get the chance to erase Adora's memories again. Catra can't help it – the revelation makes her surge forward and kiss Adora again, her tail lashing behind her as she wraps both arms around Adora's shoulders.

This time, Catra is the one making soft sounds into the kiss, but she can't help the slight whimper in her chest when Adora

immediately kisses her back, her right hand sliding to the back of Catra's neck until her blunt fingernails can drag through Catra's scruff, sending a pleased shiver through her body. That happened once before, during the make out, and it seems that Adora's body remembered it instinctually – or maybe she just thought to try it again. Regardless, it forces Catra to pull back again so she can pant a little, but she feels *satisfied*.

Seeing the surprise in Adora's face following the second kiss is a harsh wakeup call. Maybe she is surprised at her own actions, unsure how she knew to do that. Maybe she is surprised by how eagerly Catra is pressing into her. Maybe she feels an inkling of something in the back of her mind and doesn't know how to process it. Regardless, Catra can't let this go further and not tell her. She doesn't know how to go about saying this, but she doesn't think there is an easy way to tell your best friend that their memory has been wiped.

"Adora, this isn't our first kiss," Catra breathes. Adora startles a little, pulling back to get a better look at Catra's face as if she expects to realize that she is joking. Adora's brow wrinkles as she finds Catra's expression deadly serious. Catra swallows. The disbelief and confusion on her face is exactly as painful as Catra always thought it would be. She turns her face away, letting out a shaking sigh as she shifts her hand on Adora's nape to hook over her shoulder instead. Despite how she can't meet Adora's eyes for this, she needs to keep her close. *Safe*.

"It's the fifth time, actually. If you think that what you *remember* the Horde doing is bad… Shadow Weaver has been fucking with your memory. She would… make me watch when she took stuff away. As punishment for letting you kiss me," Catra admits, her voice low. The punishment was actually for kissing Adora, but Catra never did that after the first time, and she doesn't want Adora to think she would have done it knowing what she was putting Adora through. Shadow Weaver just refused to accept that Adora wasn't her perfect puppet and would want Catra like that.

"You- What?" Adora stutters, her voice small and a bit broken. Catra's ears pin back and she presses closer again, shifting her arms to wrap around Adora's shoulders and hug her tightly against her. Adora hasn't made a move to leave, but Catra is afraid that she is going to run away from her any minute.

"I kissed you the first time. Shadow Weaver caught us. Every time after that, it was you. She always found out. She would take your memories of it and punish me until I swore to never kiss you again, but then you would get that look in your eye, and I'm fucking *weak* for you," Catra explains. It killed her to hold back when she *knew* that some part of Adora wanted her. When Adora would lean forward and offer it, she could never turn away. Seeing Adora's expression crestfallen, thinking that Catra didn't want her, would be worse than anything Shadow Weaver could force her to do. Shadow Weaver was always wrong about them, but that look would have been real.

"How could- How could she do that?" Adora asks, finally managing a full sentence, but her tone is still devastated. Catra swallows and pulls back just far enough to make eye contact. Adora looks like she is on the verge of tears, her expression utterly lost. Catra wishes that she could give her an answer that would help, but the truth just makes things worse. Shadow Weaver is evil. She never had any problem doing it. She seemed to take vindictive pleasure in forcing Adora back into order, actually.

"Because her plans for you were more important to her than anyone's happiness. She's just *bad*, Adora. I never knew how much she took, but I knew that if I told you she would do it again. The only hope was for us to get enough authority of our own that she couldn't keep doing shit like that to us," Catra tells her. Adora's expression, raw with heartbreak, drives a spike of pain through Catra's chest. For a few moments, they both struggle to breathe normally.

"When Light Hope said I needed protecting from the Horde-" Adora starts, then stops. Catra's ears pin back again, a small spark

of annoyance fluttering in her heart, but she forces herself to blow out a slow breath. She struggles to sleep at night knowing this shit and she has experienced all of it. She knows it must be hard to suddenly have it all dumped in your lap and learn that you can't even trust your own memories. Still, she knows that Adora has to remember enough to know that the Horde isn't *good*.

"I might agree with Light Hope about the Horde, but I don't trust her. She talks just like Shadow Weaver does, not giving you any choice. I'm only telling you all this now because Shadow Weaver shouldn't be able to do it again from that cell," Catra tells her, managing not to sound too bitter. The important thing now is making sure that Adora understands why Catra doesn't trust either of them. She doubts Light Hope is a better option than Shadow Weaver.

Besides, they're finally on their way to getting everything that they dreamed, with even more freedom than they ever thought they could get. They don't need some hologram to tell them the truth – they can make it for themselves. Right or wrong doesn't matter as long Catra has Adora. She would burn down the world for her if she had to. Catra still has anxiety in her heart about Adora going back to Light Hope, though.

"I just want to do the right thing. This- That *isn't* right. Nothing feels right anymore," Adora confesses, quietly, screwing her eyes shut as she speaks. Catra hugs her tightly, pressing their chests together. If Adora was already having a moral crisis earlier, this certainly didn't make it any easier on her, but she deserves to know now that it isn't putting her in more danger to. Catra rests their foreheads together, the two of them standing close together in the middle of the bedroom.

"You can. We just need to figure out what *is* right before we rush into anything. You're magic now, Adora. Between your sword and *me*, we can take on anything. We'll make things right," Catra tells her, throwing in a little false bravado just to lighten things. Adora shifts her arms, wrapping them around Catra in turn and squeezing her back. She really needed that.

This isn’t how Catra imagined this conversation ending – that was always either with Adora storming away, more kissing, or Adora getting her mind wiped again – but she hugs Adora tightly. It has been a rough day on them both. They could use some time just wrapped up in each other.

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She finally knows why Catra was so insistent on only sleeping at the foot of the bed, Adora notes distantly as they finally lay down to sleep. There technically isn’t a policy against bed sharing in the Horde and other people would have sleepovers too, but theirs were always more secretive even when they were children. When they were teenagers, Catra started getting cagey about Shadow Weaver even finding her at the foot of Adora’s bed.

It makes Adora wonder when the first time that they got caught was, when Catra learned the true consequences of their closeness, but she doesn’t think she can handle finding that out tonight. It will throw the memories from around that time into sharp relief. Having everything resurface now isn’t going to help her sleep, and she needs the rest. She is at least somewhat soothed when Catra gets beneath the sheets with her, lying down beside her like she would on the rare occasions when they risked doing this back in the bunkroom.

They will have to get Catra’s stuff tomorrow, but tellingly their squad did bring over Adora’s old pillow in addition to the one that came with the bed, so they both have somewhere to rest their heads. They end up lying close together, facing each other with their legs tangling. There is just enough space between their faces so that they aren’t breathing each other’s air. The quarters are oddly dark, with their own light switch and only a small emergency light glowing dimly enough that Adora can’t make out Catra’s features, but she knows that Catra can likely see hers.

She never would have thought that they kissed before, much less *four times*. Catra made it sound like those are the only gaps in Adora's memory that she knows of, but it's terrifying to know there are things that she would be totally unaware of without Catra. Maybe there are even things that Catra doesn't remember and they are both missing. Part of Adora wants to confront Shadow Weaver and ask her why she would do such a thing – the rest of her knows exactly what the answer is. Shadow Weaver would tell her Catra is a distraction, just like she has said so many times before, but that isn't reason enough to do something like this.

"Adora. Stop Worrying. You need rest," Catra says, her voice soft. Adora startles a little, blinking into the darkness towards Catra. She wishes it was that simple. Blindly, she reaches out slowly until her hand comes into contact with Catra's soft cheek. Carefully, she cups it, rubbing her thumb back and forth and focusing on the sensation beneath her hands. Whatever she has missed, she has Catra right here now. Suddenly she doesn't care about any hell that Shadow Weaver would unleash on them if she got out. All that matters is that she took this from her and would do it again.

"What if-" Adora starts, but she cuts off when Catra's tail swats against her thigh as it lashes forward. Beneath her hand, Catra shakes her head. Adora watches her faint outline shift closer in the bed, one of Catra's arms coming up to drape over her waist so she can hug her. Catra ducks her head on the pillow to drop a kiss onto Adora's shoulder and then stays down there, letting them both breathe fresh air while pressing close together.

"No what ifs. Did you think that any of this was possible yesterday?" Catra asks her, raising a hand and gesturing out at the dark room. Adora is forced to shake her head. Catra drops her arm to wrap around Adora again. "I don't think our lives are going to be predictable for a while now. Just try to enjoy what we finally have a chance to have. I've wanted this my entire life. Haven't you?" Catra asks, her voice small and tremulously hopeful.

“Yes,” Adora breathes out before she can stop herself. She can’t name when she fell for Catra – probably because it was taken from her – but she knows that there was never any doubt that she wanted her by her side, even when they were children and Adora only thought of her as her best friend. Catra lets out a small rumble, causing Adora to gasp. Catra’s purrs are rare and she usually tries to cover them, but she lets this one roll out freely, nudging her face against Adora’s shoulder and letting her feel the vibrations roll through her.

“Then enjoy it,” Catra requests. Adora swallows. She can do that. She really wants to enjoy this moment, especially knowing how many times it has been taken from her. She feels her expression set with determination and shifts, placing a hand on Catra’s shoulder and gently tugging, encouraging her to shift up. Catra follows her prompt, holding still for Adora when she clumsily frames Catra’s face with her hands and nearly sticks a finger in her eye in the darkness. Once she has her between her hands, however, she can easily lean in and kiss Catra again.

It’s the third time. It’s the seventh. Either way, it’s the first thing to feel right all day. In her arms, Catra instantly relaxes, kissing her back as another rumble rises in her chest. Adora might have no idea what she is doing or what she *should*, but she knows that she wants to keep this. They can figure everything else out together.

Chapter End Notes

> Next fic will be Princess of the Horde, though life is going to be busy for the next two weeks so there might be a bit of a delay before I start posting it.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!